

INAUGURATION OF THAIMAAMAN THANGA MOTHIRAM THITTAM

INAUGURATION BY
THIRU.C. JOSEPH VIJAY
Hon'ble Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu



From June 22,
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**₹755.83 crore
allotted**

Date:
28.9.2026, Monday

Time:
12.00 Noon

Venue:
Government Rajaji Hospital,
Madurai



THE HINDU GROUP

A Special Publication from The Hindu Group

The Definitive Guide to the Stories Behind India's Most Impactful Editorials

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THE HINDU
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EDITORIALS
2026
A Curated Selection
VOLUME 2
April to June



Curated from
The Hindu editorials
(April–June 2026)



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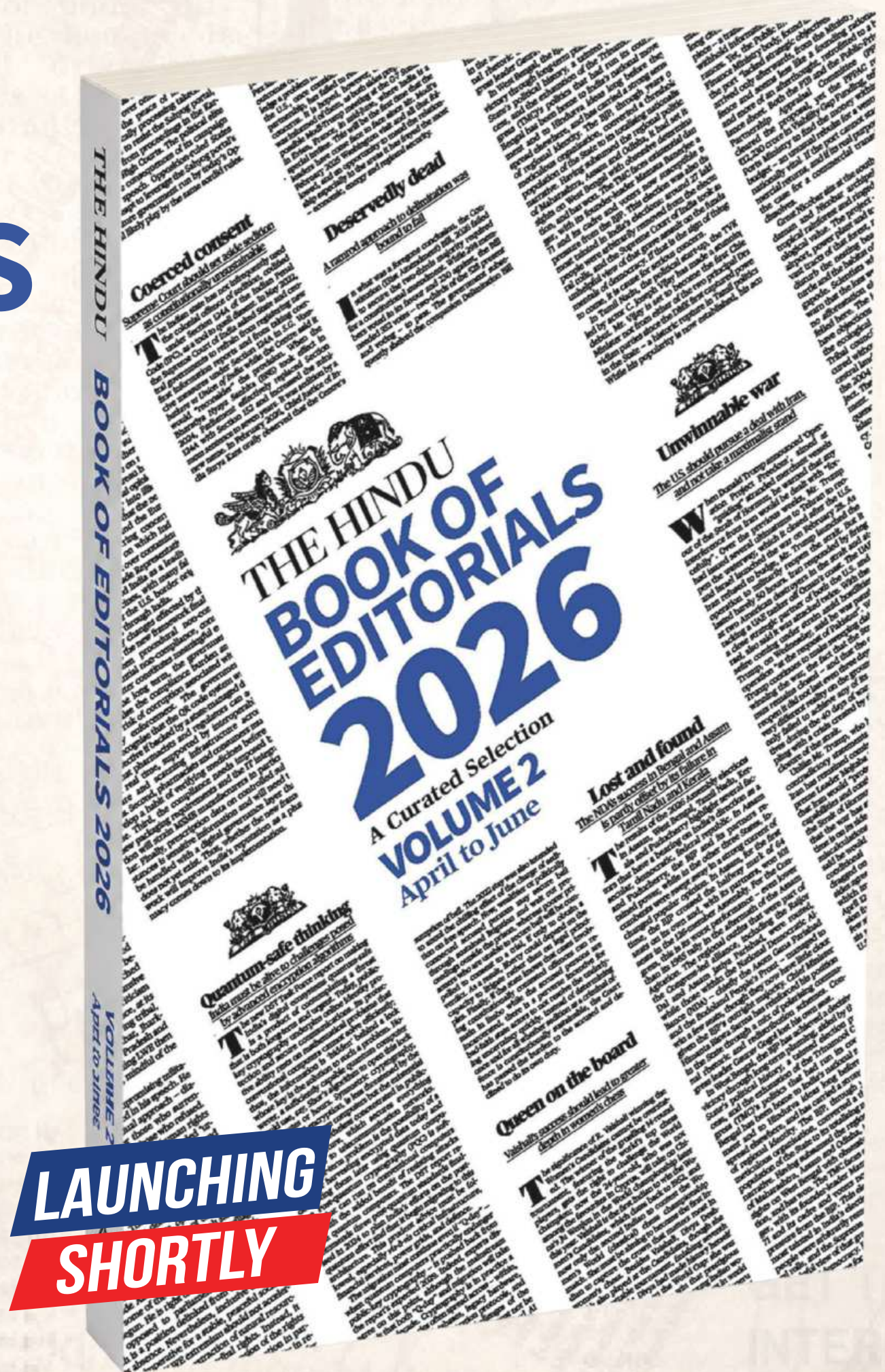
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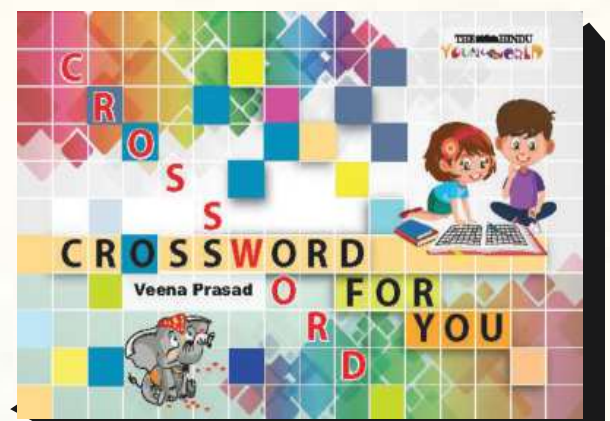

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PANEL FOR DEMANDS

Bank unions SBI defer 3-day strike after talks with IBA

NEWS » PAGE 10

EURASIAN OPPORTUNITIES

Kashmir as India's gateway

Reconnecting the Valley's historic routes could unlock its potential, writes Mehbooba

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



CHESS OLYMPIAD

Indian men win silver, women claim bronze

SPORT » PAGE 16

EC steps won't undo 'mass disenfranchisement': Cong.

Poll panel's proposed measures amount to an admission that the SIR exercise has been a 'disaster', says Congress leader; targeted removal of marginalised voters meant to benefit the BJP, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after the Election Commission announced multiple steps to address concerns about the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress on Sunday termed them a "desperate attempt at damage control" that "hides all and reveals nothing".

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the proposed measures amounted to an admission that the exercise had been a "disaster", warning that the "piecemeal" steps would do little to mitigate what he called "mass disenfranchisement".

He questioned several of the assurances given by



Congress workers take out a demonstration in Kolkata on Saturday demanding the suspension of the SIR. AP

the EC, including its proposal to review the ECINet software and plan for booth-level officers to visit the electors who received notices. "We know that in practice these visits were sparse and sporadic. What is the value of promising a second round of visits which likely will not hap-

pen? The logic of repeating a process done poorly once must be examined," he said.

Questioning the rationale of the entire SIR process, which he described as a "colossal waste" of resources, Mr. Ramesh said that nearly 14 crore voters whose names were deleted

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI against EC

NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, urging him to initiate suo motu proceedings against the conduct of the Election Commission regarding the SIR and the deployment of the ECINet software. » PAGE 11

from the rolls were now being asked to apply afresh for inclusion. The targeted removal of marginalised voters was meant to benefit the BJP, he said.

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EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8

T.N. rescinds G.O. exempting Public Dept. from RTI Act

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After facing severe backlash from political parties and activists, the Tamil Nadu government on Sunday decided to withdraw a controversial order exempting the Public (Law and Order) Department from the ambit of the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005, on the ground that it was an intelligence and security organisation.

A Government Order (dated September 21, 2026) to this effect was issued by the Human Resources Management Department under Section 24(4) of the RTI Act and then notified in the Government Gazette.

Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar wrote on X that the G.O. had been withdrawn. Speaking to repor-

The G.O., issued by the Department of Human Resources Management, drew severe backlash from political parties and activists

ters earlier in the day in Madurai, he had defended the order, saying that only certain provisions, including details of communal clashes, were kept out of the ambit of the RTI Act, given the sensitivity of the information.

Earlier, AMMK founder T.T.V. Dhinakaran, environmental activist G. Sundarajan of Poovulagin Nambargal, and Arappor Iyakkam convener Jayaram Venkatesan opposed the G.O.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

NEARBY

E.V. Velu booked in illegal lake-bed excavation case

CHENNAI

The DVAC has registered a case against DMK MLA E.V. Velu and others for unauthorised excavation of lake-bed material for levelling the venue of a DMK event in 2025. » PAGE 6

Ex-Minister moves HC to quash FIR against him

CHENNAI

Former Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi has moved the Madras High Court to quash an FIR over the alleged illegal collection of over ₹100 crore from private schools. » PAGE 6

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5

Joy unbound



Ecstatic: Ancy Sojan is over the moon after winning the silver medal in the women's long jump at the Asian Games on Sunday. Sarvesh Kushare (high jump), Anahat Singh, and Abhay Singh (squash) too won silver medals on Sunday. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 15)

5 'terrorists' held near U.K. base used by U.S.

Agence France-Presse
FAIRFORD

British counter-terrorism forces were probing "a major incident" near a base used by the U.S. Air Force in its war against Iran after arresting five men on suspicion of "preparing a terrorist act", the police said on Sunday.

Armed officers detained the group in the early hours after a call to emergency services about three "suspicious vehicles which appeared to be travelling towards the air base", London's Metropolitan Police said in a statement.

U.S. President Donald Trump said that the suspects were aiming at doing significant damage to the



A U.S. B-1B Lancer bomber on the tarmac of the Fairford air base on Sunday. REUTERS

base. "We had them under investigation... they were looking to do big damage to our fort, and working with the British worked out great," he told presspersons. "We had them under view for a long time, and we got them," he added.

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Iran stands firm on plan for reopening Hormuz Strait

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON/TEHRAN

Iran stood firm on Sunday on its conditions for reopening the Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. President Donald Trump's rejection of the proposal, leaving the war in West Asia locked in a stalemate.

"Our conditions are clear, and any move toward reopening the Strait of Hormuz is contingent upon these conditions being fulfilled. We will not back down from them," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 14

Policeman risks life to nab gutkha smugglers

Wilson Thomas
COIMBATORE

In a high-octane chase that looked like something out of a movie, a Coimbatore policeman clung onto the roof rails of an SUV for over 40 km as three persons from Rajasthan attempted to escape with banned tobacco products.

M. Velmurugan, 38, a head constable attached to the Kovilpalayam police station in the district, held onto the roof rails of the SUV, which had about 230 kg of gutkha. The chase started from Kaikolapalayam in the jurisdiction of the Kovilpalayam station around 5.45 a.m. According to senior officers, they had specific information on the smuggling of



M. Velmurugan holds onto the roof rails of the SUV. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

banned tobacco products from Bengaluru to Coimbatore.

A team, led by Neelambur Inspector P. Thiagarajan, identified the suspected white SUV bearing a Karnataka registration number at Vellanaipatti.

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25 km in raging river amid crocodiles, the longest night for 75-year-old Odisha woman

Septuagenarian from Jajpur survives 12 hours in the swollen Brahmani river after falling into it at night; she braves strong floodwaters before being rescued from a neighbouring district on Sunday

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

For more than 12 hours in pitch darkness, Keshi Dalai, 75, clung to life as the raging Brahmani river in Odisha carried her through swollen floodwaters for nearly 25 km.

With crocodiles lurking in the turbulent waters and the river showing no mercy, every passing minute brought her closer to death. Yet, against all odds, the septuagenarian survived the ordeal and was rescued alive on



Keshi Dalai after her rescue in Kendrapara of Odisha on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sunday morning. Ms. Dalai, a resident of Kalakhanda, a riverside village in Jajpur district, had gone to the riverbank to relieve herself late on Saturday evening while her family was asleep. She

was swept away by the Brahmani river, which was in spate following heavy rain, after she lost her balance.

The stretch of the Brahmani where she fell in is known for its crocodiles. Residents have erected barricades in the water at several places for protection. More than 20 people have been dragged into the river by crocodiles over the past five years. Against this backdrop, Ms. Dalai's survival through the dead of night is being hailed as nothing short of a miracle.

Throughout the night,

Ms. Dalai managed to remain afloat. On Sunday morning, she was spotted waving for help and was rescued by a group of youth at Balipatna village in Kendrapara district – at a distance of 25 km by river course and 45 km by road from her village. "In the morning, we could not find her. As the search continued, a call from the Pattamundai police in Kendrapara brought us immense relief," said Aranya Dalai, Ms. Dalai's son-in-law.

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Protests erupt over Punjab 'campus rape'

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

Allegations that a student was raped on the campus of Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab sparked an agitation that led to protesters, mainly students, blocking National Highway-44 near Phagwara on Sunday.

The stir, which took place hours after the protesters went on a rampage and vandalised university property, disrupted traffic and led to clashes with the police.

The police registered a first information report (FIR) containing rape charges against unknown persons and a special investigation team has been constituted to probe the



Protesters block the National Highway near LPU campus in Punjab on Sunday. PTI

matter. The students have alleged that a female hosteller had been raped by a plumber three days ago and claimed that no action had been taken in the matter so far. LPU, a private institute, has denied the allegations.

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INBRIEF



Walkathon held to raise awareness on heart health

A five-km walkathon to raise awareness on cardiovascular health, importance of physical activity, and preventive care was held in Chennai on Sunday to mark the upcoming World Heart Day. The ‘SIMS Rhythm of Life’ walkathon was flagged off from the hospital premises in Vadapalani by Raju Sivasamy, vice-president, SIMS Hospital, along with K. Jai Shankar, senior director and senior consultant, Cardiology, and T.S. Srinath, director and senior consultant, Cardiology. This year’s theme is ‘Heart diseases can hide in plain sight: Don’t miss a beat’.

Stampede left an indelible scar on T.N.: Chief Minister

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday paid homage to those who lost their lives in the Karur stampede on its first anniversary. In a post on X, Mr. Vijay recalled the stampede at a political rally addressed by him at Velusampuram in Karur on September 27, 2025, in which 41 people were killed. He said the incident had left an indelible scar in his life, in the lives of the people of Karur, and in the hearts of the people across Tamil Nadu. “For those who are grieving the loss of our loved ones, let us be there for one another as a source of comfort, support, and strength.”

Work on stormwater drain near Virugambakkam canal to be completed in 2 weeks

GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran inspects development works under way at the canal, including the construction of retaining walls and removal of silt and waste, at an estimated cost of ₹30 crore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The stormwater drain work on Kaliyamman Koil Street, at a point where it joins the Virugambakkam canal, will be completed within two weeks, Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) Commissioner G.S. Sameeran said during an inspection on Sunday.

Mr. Sameeran inspected the development works under way at the Virugambakkam canal in Kodambakkam zone at an estimated cost of ₹30 crore. The works included construction of retaining walls, fencing, and removal of silt and waste.

He also inspected the construction of a bridge across the canal by the Chennai Metro Rail Limited at an estimated cost of ₹12 crore.

The existing bridge was being removed as part of the work. Officials were instructed to construct the



Pre-monsoon measure: The storm-water drain work under way on Kaliyamman Koil Street, at a point where it joins the Virugambakkam canal in Kodambakkam zone. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

bridge before the North-east monsoon.

The Virugambakkam waterway canal begins at Bhuvaneshwari Nagar in Virugambakkam, and passes through Chinmaya Nagar, Saligramam, and M.M.D.A. Colony, before joining the Cooum.

The canal is 6.70 km in

length and 8-25 m in width.

Mr. Sameeran also inspected dengue prevention measures in Kodambakkam zone.

MGR canal

He visited the MGR canal and reviewed mosquito-control spraying before conducting a door-to-door

field inspection on 2nd Sector, 13th Street.

The Commissioner also distributed awareness pamphlets to residents and advised them to prevent water stagnation, remove unwanted articles, maintain cleanliness, and seek immediate medical treatment in case of fever.



Improving access: The 3,000-litre water ATM can dispense 20-litre cans at ₹5 each. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

MSSRF sets up water ATM at its Perungudi heat stress study site

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF) has inaugurated a water ATM at its heat stress study site in Perungudi, to improve access to drinking water. The 3,000-litre water ATM can dispense 20-litre cans at ₹5 each.

Mohan Kumar, director, Health Systems and Nutrition, MSSRF, said the initiative followed feedback from residents during field visits about the lack of access to drinking water.

The foundation is conducting a four-year longitudinal study across four sites in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka to assess the impact of heat on physical and mental health. Perungudi and Poompuram in Mayiladuthurai are the two study sites in Tamil Nadu, while Sirwar in Raichur district, and Challakere in Chitradurga district are the sites in Karnataka.

“We wanted to make an

immediate contribution to the community we are working with. Unlike water ATMs that dispense smaller quantities, this allows residents to collect 20 litres at a time at a minimal cost,” Dr. Kumar said. MSSRF plans to set up similar facilities at its other study sites.

MSSRF chairperson Soumya Swaminathan, who inaugurated the facility, said the foundation would assess its usefulness and explore other practical interventions based on the findings of the study.

The inauguration also featured an exhibition of photographs taken by local youngsters, as part of a photovoice study on heat and nutrition.

The broader heat study aims at assessing household and individual heat exposure, heat-related illnesses, coping mechanisms, mental health and well-being, and the preparedness of health systems to respond to heat-related situations.

Centre for Mental Health, Social Care and Livelihoods launched

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In an effort to extend social support and care to persons with mental illness, Chennai-based NGO The Banyan, Aaladamara Foundation, and the Banyan Academy of Leadership in Mental Health (BALM) inaugurated the Centre for Mental Health, Social Care, and Livelihoods, and the Last Mile Mental Health and Social Care Praxis Lab on Sunday.

Speaking at the event, former Chief Secretary of Kerala S.M. Vijayanand said, “Village panchayats are in the front line of any service delivery. When the



Patron of The Banyan's centre Deanna Jejeebhoy during the inauguration held at Savera hotel on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

government disappears, the panchayats and SHGs (self-help groups) work together in most parts of India.”

Mr. Vijayanand added that they were repositories of social capital, and that they also help raise aware-

ness of mental health in the local community.

The centre brings clinical, social, and economic responses together as one integrated approach across five domains: income and social protection, livelihoods, relational stability,

support for vulnerable caregivers, and access to basic healthcare.

A press release said the lab would study how social determinants and structural violence, including poverty and homelessness, influence mental health care practice.

Information asymmetry

Director of The Hindu Group N. Ram said information asymmetry could weaken the administration and effectiveness of social care formulations for people with severe mental illness. “The problem is particularly prominent in India because information is distributed through

structures already marked by class, caste, education, and gender inequalities. It is important to remember that power determines which information counts,” he said.

Deanna Jejeebhoy, patron of the centre and Ratan Tata’s sister, and Mr. Ram unveiled the centre and the lab respectively.

Co-CEO of BALM Preetha Krishnadas said, “Our health is shaped by the conditions in which we live, work and age, yet care systems stabilise symptoms and send people back to the very conditions that caused them distress. When they return, we call it relapse and locate the fai-

lure in the person rather than in the structure.”

Role of legal aid

Advocate Gitanjali Diwakar said that while the courts in India are burdened, the role of legal aid goes beyond providing case expertise and strategy to making time for people and communicating with empathy and sensitivity.

Actor Revathi, Commissioner of Central Taxes S. Nagarajan, Co-CEO of The Banyan Archana Padmakar, former Advocate General of Tamil Nadu P.S. Raman, and CEO of Aaladamara Foundation Mrinalini Ravi participated in the launch.

Man who claimed a share of Jayalalithaa’s property as her ‘half-brother’ is dead, HC told

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court has been told that N.J. Vasudevan, 86, who had filed a case in 2023 seeking 50% share in the properties left behind by former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa by claiming to be her half-brother, died in Mysuru, Karnataka, on June 2, 2026.

Appearing before a Division Bench of Justices Abdul Quddus and R. Rajesh Vivekananthan, advocate S.L. Sudharsanam, representing Jayalalithaa’s niece J. Deepa and nephew J. Deepak, said the applicant was no more and produced a news report on the death. The judges directed the High Court Registry to verify the statement and send a notice to the applicant’s address in Mysuru to find out if anyone was interested in substituting him.

The matter was adjourned to November 5, 2026, for further hearing. The applicant had approached the court in 2023, urging it to revoke an order passed by Justice N. Kirubakaran (since retired) and Justice Quddus on May 27, 2020, when Ms.

N.J. Vasudevan, 86, had filed a case in 2023, seeking 50% share in the former CM’s properties

Deepa and Mr. Deepak were declared inheritors of their aunt’s properties.

Claiming to have been born to the first wife of Jayalalithaa’s father, the applicant said his mother had filed a case in 1950, seeking maintenance from his father. He asserted a right to 50% of Jayalalithaa’s properties, and urged the court to revoke its declaration in favour of Ms. Deepa and Mr. Deepak.

In 2020, the Bench led by Justice Kirubakaran said the siblings would be entitled to inherit all self-acquired properties of their aunt and the properties inherited by their aunt from her parents, as per the Hindu Succession Act, 1956.

It highlighted that Section 15(1) of the Act states that the self-acquired properties left behind by a female Hindu, who dies intestate, shall devolve firstly upon her sons and daughters (including the children of any predeceased son or

daughter) and the husband. Then they would devolve upon the heirs of the husband, and thirdly upon the mother and father.

Only if none of them were available, the properties would devolve upon the heirs of the father. Since Mr. Deepak and his sister were the children of Jayalalithaa’s brother J. Jayakumar (who predeceased her), the siblings would be entitled to inherit her self-acquired properties under Section 15(1)(d), the Bench held.

Further, Section 15(2)(a) of the Act states that any property inherited by a female Hindu from her father or mother shall devolve, in the absence of any son or daughter of the deceased, not upon the other heirs in the order specified in Section 15(1), but upon the heirs of the father.

Therefore, properties such as Veda Nilayam, the residence of Jayalalithaa at Poes Garden in Chennai, which she inherited from her mother in 1971, would also go to Ms. Deepa and Mr. Deepak, since they were the children of Jayakumar, who was one of the legal heirs of Jayalalithaa’s father, the court had ruled.

Webinar held on vaccine schedules and missed doses

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Vaccine schedules, catch-up vaccination, and common misconceptions about immunisation were among the issues discussed by doctors at The Hindu’s Health Webinar Series on ‘Vaccines: Armour Against Infectious Diseases’ held on Sunday.

Janani Sankar, medical director, Kanchi Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital, Chennai, explained the recommended vaccination schedule for children, the importance of completing the required doses, and what parents can do when a child misses a scheduled vaccine.

She also addressed questions about vaccination during minor illnesses, such as a cold, cough or fever, and concerns about children receiving multiple vaccines.

Common reactions

Dr. Sankar discussed common reactions following vaccination and symptoms that may require medical attention, as well as vaccines recommended for children in specific situations.

Dilip Mathai, senior con-

sultant in Infectious Diseases, Naruvi Hospitals, and Professor of Medicine and Adult Infectious Diseases, discussed vaccination in adults, including how vaccination needs may change with age and individual circumstances.

He explained options for adults who do not have records of earlier vaccinations, and the role of catch-up vaccination.

Travel vaccination

He also discussed travel vaccination, including the need to consider recommended vaccines based on the destination and travel plans.

Vaccination during pregnancy and considerations for people taking long-term medicines or living with chronic conditions were also discussed.

The doctors also addressed questions on vaccine safety, side-effects, information circulating on social media, vaccination after an infectious disease, and immunisation during outbreaks.

The webinar was moderated by Athira Elssa Johnson, senior reporter, The Hindu. The webinar can be viewed at newsth.live/vaccination.

CINEMA ARTS EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras Today: At the Kasthuri Srinivasan Hall, 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. – Violin Vidwan Lalgudi Sri G. Jayaraman Memorial Endowment – H.K.Venkatram & B.U. Ganesh Prasad (Violin Duet), Neyveli S.Skandasubramaniam (Mridangam), Adambakkam K. Sankar (Ghatam). Programme under the endowment Instituted by Lalgudi Shri. G.J.R. Krishnan & Lalgudi Smt. Vijayalakshmi. Programme supported by KVB CSR initiative.

Naada Inbam, 24992672 A Musical Visit to Vishnu Shrines – Bhavya Hari, Veena Venkatramani (Veena) & Preeti Sethuraman with B. Sivaraman & N. Guruprasad. Concert dedicated to Smt. Andal & Sri V. Ananthanarayanan. Today 6.15 p.m. at Ragasudha Hall.

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SIVANISAI MUSIC FESTIVAL - 2026 On the occasion of 136th Birthday Celebrations of Brahmesri Papanasai Sivan Today at Sathguru Gnanananda Hall, Narada Gana Sabha.

5.00 PM - “Melodies of Sri.Papanasai Sivan”- Vocal Concert by Vid.Bharat Sundar with Vid. Rajeev Mukundan, Vid.Anirudh Raj and Vid.K.V.Gopalakrishnan 7.00 PM - “Film Hits of Sri.Papanasai Sivan”- Veena by Vid.Rajesh Vaidhya with Vid.Bharathi & Vid.Manikandan on Keyboard, Vid.Sathish on Flute, Vid.Maharajaraman on Mridangam, Vid.Ganapathi on Tabla and Vid.Subramanian on Timing.

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I, MIRGA Devi dependent of Sanjay Choudhary, resident of Air Force Station Avadi, Tamilnadu- 600055 have changed my name from Mirga Devi to Mirgi Devi vide affidavit No. FC 771704 dated 16 Sep 26 before G Latha ML, Advocate Avadi, Chennai

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Timings CHENNAI

MONDAY, SEP. 28		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:01
RISE	19:09	SET 07:10
TUESDAY, SEP. 29		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:01
RISE	19:56	SET 08:07
WEDNESDAY, SEP. 30		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:00
RISE	20:49	SET 09:08

Man dies after tree branch falls on him

A 70-year-old man from Andhra Pradesh, who was undergoing treatment for injuries sustained after a tree branch fell on him in Royapettah last week, died on Sunday.

S. Ramanappa was walking on the Pattulos Road on September 24 when the branch fell on him.

TNPCB tells NGT Sun Pharma did not implement proposed expansion in Chengalpattu

The company obtained environmental clearance from the Centre for increasing its production. TNPCB said the company, however, had not got the Board's 'consent to operate' for the expansion

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) has told the National Green Tribunal (NGT) that Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd.'s unit at Sathammai village in Chengalpattu district is currently operating within its existing permitted production capacity and has not undertaken the proposed expansion.

The submission was made in a recent report filed before the southern bench of the NGT following an appeal filed by K.R. Selvaraj Kumar of Meenavar Nala Sangam, challenging the environmental clearance granted to the company for expansion.

Consent to establish

According to the TNPCB report, the unit had originally obtained the Board's consent to establish in 2005 and consent to operate in 2006 for manufac-



A recent TNPCB inspection found that the unit was in operation but its production was within the existing consented capacity.

turing pharmaceutical products with a total production capacity of 25.5 tonnes a month. Subsequent consent orders permitted changes in sewage generation, trade effluent disposal and air pollution control measures, without an increase in the permitted product quantity.

The company later obtained environmental clearance from the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change on March 31, 2022, for in-

creasing its production capacity from 25.5 tonnes per month to 134.082 tonnes per month for active pharmaceutical ingredients within the existing plant. However, the TNPCB said the company had not obtained the Board's consent to establish or consent to operate for the expansion.

A TNPCB inspection conducted on September 12, 2026, found that the unit was in operation but its production was within the existing consented capaci-

ty of 25.5 tonnes a month. The Board also recorded that no expansion activity had been carried out.

The dispute also relates to an earlier NGT order in an original application filed in 2020. The Tribunal had noted violations relating to the unit's operation without environmental clearance for an earlier expansion and had confirmed an environmental compensation of ₹58.20 lakh for contamination of groundwater and soil. It had also directed payment of an interim compensation of ₹10 crore and asked the TNPCB to assess any additional compensation for operation beyond the permitted pollution load.

The TNPCB report said the company subsequently obtained the 2022 environmental clearance for the proposed expansion and renewed consent from the Board valid up to March 31, 2028, but had not obtained consent specifically for carrying out the expansion.

Greater Chennai Corporation to set up Amma Canteen at Omandurar hospital

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) is planning to set up an Amma Canteen at the Omandurar Government Multi Super Speciality Hospital, with an estimated additional annual expenditure of ₹20.53 lakh, after accounting for projected food sales.

Recently *The Hindu* had reported on the need for low cost food at the hospital.

An online petition was also launched by some members of civil society appealing to the Chief Minister to establish an Amma Canteen at the hospital. The civic body has now



The Corporation has sought the government approval to establish the Amma Canteen.

said the facility would provide quality, low-cost food to patients and their attendants.

The GCC has sought retrospective government approval to establish the Amma Canteen and permission to undertake the building, electrical, equip-

ment, raw material and other works required to commence operations.

With an estimated 150 beneficiaries a day, annual sales are projected at ₹16.43 lakh. The balance expenditure of ₹20.53 lakh will have to be met from Corporation funds, according to the civic body.

According to the GCC, a site near Tower-7, close to the outpatient department entrance, has been identified. The existing children's ward was subsequently inspected and found suitable. It has a kitchen, dishwashing and food distribution facilities, dining space, raw material storage, handwashing facilities and toilets. Only mi-

nor infrastructure improvements are required, the GCC said.

The facility is expected to involve a first-year expenditure of ₹36.96 lakh, including ₹5.52 lakh for building maintenance, ₹6.50 lakh for machinery and utensils, ₹16.80 lakh for raw materials, ₹7.12 lakh towards wages for six Women Self-Help Group members and ₹1.02 lakh in petty expenses. The six workers will be paid ₹325 a day each.

Food will be sold at subsidised rates: *idli* at ₹1; *pongal*, sambar rice, lemon rice and curry leaf rice at ₹5 each; and curd rice and two chapatis with dal at ₹3 each.

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	37	26
Chennai Airport	38	29
Chennai City	38	28

Chennai Airport Today
37°C The weather will be dry. The day will be very warm. The night will be comfortable.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be very warm. The night will be comfortable. Light rain and thundershowers likely.

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Tracheal stents offer relief to dog breeds prone to breathing problems; veterinarians trained in city

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

Taking a step forward in interventional veterinary medicine, the Chennai Small Animal Veterinarians Association (CSAVA), in collaboration with the Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences University (TANUVAS), on Sunday conducted a hands-on training programme for veterinarians from across the country on canine tracheal stenting procedure. The procedure is used in treating dogs, particularly small breeds, suffering from tracheal collapse and strictures.

"This is the first time in India that we are performing this procedure for dogs that fail to respond to clini-



Veterinarians examine a dog during a training programme on placing a stent to treat tracheal collapse on Sunday. V. UMESH KUMAR

cal management. Persistent goose honk cough is one of the symptoms," said G.R. Baranidharan, president CSAVA, who received training in the procedure in the U.S.

The programme was held at Madras Veterinary College (MVC), which has a fluoroscopy unit – a real-

time X-ray system that helps assess the depth of the trachea and identify abnormalities. The procedure involves the use of an endoscope and a specialised tool to deploy the stent in the area where the windpipe had collapsed.

Dr. Baranidharan, along with G. Vijayakumar, Head

of Clinics at MVC, demonstrated the procedure on cadavers and live animals with the help of an endoscope.

"Tracheal collapse and strictures are common in brachycephalic breeds such as Pugs, Shih Tzus and Boxers. Heavy inbreeding causes breathing problems in these breeds," said Dr. Vijayakumar.

While stents specifically designed for animals are available in Europe and the U.S., India currently relies on stents manufactured for human use. "Fluoroscopic studies will help us measure and select the stent suitable for dogs," Dr. Baranidharan said.

The procedure can provide significant relief to affected animals, but the

cost remains a concern. "A stent costs around ₹60,000, and we are placing them free of cost for animals as part of the training programme," Dr. Baranidharan said.

Dr. Vijayakumar said government support, pet medical insurance and subsidies for procuring stents could help make the procedure more accessible to animals in need.

This facility currently is available at the Department of Veterinary Medicine headed by Ram Prabu.

The combination of bronchoscopy, fluoroscopy, and stent deploying instruments can increase longevity and quality of dogs with tracheal collapse.

Youth murdered over obscene messages in Mangadu, 2 arrested

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Mangadu police have arrested two persons for the murder of a 20-year-old youth on Saturday.

A senior officer of the Avadi police Commissionerate said, on Saturday, Yuvanesh, a resident of Mangadu, was found dead in a well, with his body tied to a heavy stone.

Based on the complaint filed by one of his parents, the Mangadu police filed a case of murder.

Following investigation, the police arrested Devadhayalan alias Vicky and Parthiban, who were

Police said the two confessed that they killed Yuvanesh, as he had sent obscene messages and images to one of the accused's girlfriend

known to the victim, in connection with the murder. The duo allegedly confessed to the police that they killed Yuvanesh as he sent obscene messages and images to Devadhayalan's girlfriend.

The two accused were later produced before a judicial magistrate and sent to prison.

THE HINDU

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THE HINDU

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TNPDCL proposes to outsource domestic meters assessment as interim measure

R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDCL) has proposed to outsource the bi-monthly assessment of meter readings of domestic consumers in the State for six months, until the smart meters are installed.

The TNPDCL has been reeling under severe manpower shortage in all categories including linemen, wiremen, supervisors, and assessors. At present the TNPDCL faces a 60% vacancy crunch of assessor positions, with only 3,063 assessors available against a sanctioned strength of 7,565, serving roughly 3.50 crore low-tension connections.

The shortage of assessors in Chennai, with nearly 40 lakh domestic consumers, has resulted in hundreds of complaints regarding consumers receiving inflated electricity bills due to delayed meter assessment and table reading (assessment without visiting the houses).

Under this proposal, the TNPDCL has also given the authority to Executive Engineers (who would be controlling 20 section offices) to call for tenders to appoint private contractors for the exercise.

A senior official said the interim measure has been proposed to ensure prompt assessment of all LT (non-commercial) connections, and also to avoid complaints from consumers regarding delayed meter assessments.

As per the tender document, the private contractor has been stipulated to assess 250 meters per day in Greater Chennai Corporation limits, 220 in other Corporations, 200 in municipal towns, 180 in town

panchayats, 110 in rural areas, and 80 in hill regions. The private assessors would have to carry out the assessment by using a mobile app through an optical probe, a blue-tooth transmitter, or a manual key by engaging outside staff.

While the proposal was welcomed by a section of the operation and maintenance engineers, whose regular duty has been hit because of the assessors shortage, several electricity trade unions are concerned that the interim outsourcing would lead to privatisation of more works.

An electricity official at a section office in South Chennai said, already several retired assessors have been engaged to carry out meter assessment by fixing an amount of ₹5 per meter, but not many were willing to take up the job.

A. Sekkizhar, secretary of the Tamil Nadu Electricity Board Employees' Federation, requested TNPDCL to cancel the proposal, and said the federation has planned to hold a protest on Monday. He said the assessment of meters was a specialised job that demands a certain level of qualification. Moreover, once privatised it could lead to more job privatisation, he added.

Consumer activists are also concerned about the efficiency of assessments that would be carried out by private contractors, who they said, may not bear the responsibility of their job to assess 250 meters a day.

Social activist S. Kumararaja said the best way for the TNPDCL is to speed up the installation of smart meters, at least in the city, and allow self-assessment as a temporary measure.

Pulicat fishermen urge T.N., Andhra govts. to demarcate fishing grounds using GPS

Representatives of fishing hamlets say they could no longer depend on palmyrah tree trunks as demarcations; a community leader calls for withdrawal of cases registered on fishermen from T.N.



Conflict resolution: Fishermen who took part in a joint meeting on Sunday said disputes could arise if new palmyrah tree trunks are placed as demarcations to replace the old ones. They urged the State governments to mark their areas as soon as possible. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Fishermen of Pulicat - from Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh - have urged both the State governments to mark the respective fishing grounds using global positioning systems (GPS).

In a joint meeting held in Tiruvallur district on Saturday, the fishermen representing 25 fishing hamlets that depend on the brackish waters lake that sprawls across the two States, said that they could no longer depend on the

palmyrah tree trunks that were placed as demarcations. The tree trunks rot as they stand in the salt water and when new trunks are placed, disputes could arise. MLAs and officials from Sulurpetta in Andhra Pradesh and Tiruvallur took part in the meeting.

Sources said, after the violent incidents of April 2014, when houses, boats, nets and engines of Chinna Mangodu village in Pulicat were set afire by Andhra Pradesh fishermen in retaliation following a fishing border dispute, men from Tamil Nadu have refrained

from fishing in waters under the control of Andhra Pradesh.

“We had imposed strict control and someone would only very rarely fish in those areas. A total of 199 police cases are still pending against men from fishing hamlets in Tamil Nadu. We want the dispute to be settled once and for all. Fishermen from both the States have been staging protests and submitting petitions to the respective district administrations,” said a source.

After hearing both

sides, the Tiruvallur District Collector S. Kavitha and Tirupathi Additional Collector R. Govinda Rao decided that the present system of fishing would continue until the respective governments take a call.

Fishing community leader Durai Mahendran said the GPS marking should carried out as soon as possible. “Fishermen are suffering due to this. Clear marking would bring peace to the villages. Also, the cases on men from Tamil Nadu should be dropped,” he added.

Sanskrit scholar R. Krishnamurthy Shastri passes away

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Renowned Sanskrit scholar and former principal of the Madras Sanskrit College, *Mahamahopadhyaya* R. Krishnamurthy Shastri passed away at his home on Sunday afternoon. He was 82.

Family sources said, even on Sunday, he had performed the *Mahalaya tarpana*. On September 23, he attended an event at Orikkai in Kancheepuram, where the pontiffs of the Kanchi Sankara Mutt are observing Chaturmasyam. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat was present on the occasion.

He was born in 1944 in Mullaivaasal village, as the second son of Brahmarshi Rajagopala Ghanapathigal and his wife Balamba. He studied the Vedas under the guidance of his father. Subsequently, he studied Vedanta and Shastras at the Madras Sanskrit College and successfully completed the Vedanta Shiromani and Mimamsa Shiromani examinations. He obtained an M.A. in Sanskrit from Sri Venkateswara University and then earned his Doctorate from the University of Madras, researching the subject *Ish-tasiddhivivarana*.

He began his teaching career as a Sanskrit Pandit at Vaideeswara Oriental School, Mettur, where he served from 1964 to 1973. In 1973, he was appointed as a lecturer in Vedanta at Madras Sanskrit College.



Mahamahopadhyaya
R. Krishnamurthy Shastri.

Thereafter, he served as vice-principal at the Sri Venkateswara Vedic University, Tirumala.

He became the principal of Madras Sanskrit College in 1999. He passed the Vedabhashya examination in first class and was honoured with the title *Vedabhashyaratnam*. Several Peethadhipatis and educational institutions conferred upon him titles including *Shastralankara*, *Vedanta Visharada*, *Advaita Siddhanta*, and *Advaita-vada Visharada*.

In 1999, the Rashtriya Sanskrit Vidyapeetha, Tirupati, conferred upon him the prestigious title Mahamahopadhyaya. He was honoured in 2013 by the President of India with the President's Award.

He has authored several works, including, *Siddhanta-traya-sara* in Tamil, *Vedanta-Prashnottara-Ratnamalika* in Sanskrit, and *Shastrartha-Sumanjari* in Sanskrit. After retiring, he established the Brahmavidya Bhavanam, where he taught Veda, Veda-Bhashya, and Vedanta.

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202623 5212325	Complete wiring work in LHB & Amrit Bharat LWLRM, LSLRD, LVPH & LWCB Coaches including handling and installation of equipment and harness preparation activities at ICF Chennai.	4,86,56,922/-	16.10.2026 15:00 Hrs.

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INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI-38

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202647 6212342	Servicing of Air End Unit of Screw Compressor Inv.No. 70338 available in Furnishing Division.	5,84,170/-	12.10.2026 15:00 Hrs.

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Dy.Chief Mechanical Engineer / Plant

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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Smt. Geetha Murthi

With profound grief we inform the sad and sudden demise of our beloved Smt. Geetha Murthi known as R S Geetha to her school/college mates, who left for heavenly abode on 23rd September 2026 at 5.20pm.

In grief

Srinivasamurthi, sons Kiran Murthi, Vivek Murthi & family, Ph: +91 94449 52193

DEATH

Uma Sobana N

With profound sorrow, we regret to inform you of the passing of our beloved Uma Sobana N who peacefully departed for her heavenly abode on Sunday, 27.09.2026 at 11:45 a.m. A beloved wife, mother, and cherished member of the family, her dynamic and charismatic personality, caring and loving nature, and unwavering willpower touched the lives of everyone around her. She will be deeply missed and forever remembered with love and gratitude.

Swaminathan, Divya, Sivakumar, Siddharth, Sanjana, family and friends

Sivakumar +91 98404 29369

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

First Anniversary

C P RADHA
(Radha Jayalakshmi - Carnatic Musicians)

Deeply mourned by Sumathi Rangarajan (Sister) Karthik Rangarajan (Nephew)

Ph: 75500 90231

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FOURTH ANNIVERSARY

I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race I have kept the faith - 2 Timothy 4:7

THEODORE GEORGE

Founder of GESCO HEALTHCARE PRIVATE LIMITED

Man of Faith, Wisdom, and Grace. Mentor & an Inspirational Guide. A Father who did not tell us how to live He lived and set an example

Missing you every Day But your legacy continues. Fondly Remembered by Children, Grandchildren & Great Grandchildren

SAD DEMISE

B.KAMALA (97 years)

Fondly Kamalamma of Chinmaya Mission General Manager (Retd.) Canara Bank

Attained Heavenly Abode on 27.09.2026 at Srinagar Colony, Saidapet, Chennai

Your prayers will serve as acknowledgement

Deeply Mourned by Family Members

Mob: 88389 20144 / 97909 90668

OBITUARY

Mrs. JOHANNE SELVAKUMAR

Age: 79 years w/o Dr. R. A. SELVAKUMAR

Funeral Service on 28.09.2026 at 9.30 AM, CSI Egmore Wesley Church, Egmore, Chennai.

Burial, 11.30 AM, Kilpauk Cemetery

Deeply mourned by Family & Friends

Contact: 8511816520 Emmanuel 8220004244 Christy

9th Anniversary

DR.T.SIVASANKARAN

A Life that led many lives. Fondly remembered by FAMILY MEMBERS

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Padmakumar Nair

Few topics in higher education receive as much attention as industry-academia collaboration. Every policy document, accreditation framework, and university strategy seems to ask the same question: What must universities do differently to become more relevant to industry?

While it is an important question, I increasingly wonder whether we have been asking the wrong one. Over the years, we have created an idealised picture of university-industry collaboration. Every student should complete a meaningful internship. Every professor should work on industry-sponsored research. Universities and companies should jointly develop products, technologies, and services. Graduates should seamlessly transition into employment. It is an inspiring vision, but is it practical?

According to the All-India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), India produces around one crore graduates every year. But the country generates only about 10 to 15 lakh entry-level graduate jobs annually. The economy, undoubtedly, creates many more jobs, but relatively few are high-skilled positions requiring a university degree.

This mismatch fundamentally changes the discussion. Even if every company genuinely wanted to collaborate with universities, can industry realistically provide quality internships for millions of students every year? Can companies dedicate engi-



neers, managers, scientists, and designers to mentor such numbers? Can every faculty member undertake industry-funded research? Can every university sustain advanced laboratories capable of supporting collaborative product development?

Capacity matters
Meaningful collaboration depends on several important preconditions. Students must possess sufficient technical competence before entering the industry. Companies must have the organisational bandwidth to supervise interns and collaborative projects. Faculty members must be engaged in high-quality research

that industry finds valuable. Universities must possess research infrastructure, labs, and administrative systems capable of supporting sustained partnerships.

Internationally, countries such as Germany, Japan, South Korea, and several European nations have built stronger university-industry ecosystems that evolved through decades of sustained industrial development, strong research universities, and carefully designed public policies.

Even the U.S., often regarded as the benchmark for innovation, does not achieve the universal model of industry-academia collaboration that many

discussions implicitly assume. Outstanding partnerships are concentrated in particular universities, industries, and research-intensive institutions rather than being the norm across the entire higher education system.

Questions to ask
Perhaps, then, the issue is not that universities are underperforming but that our expectations are unrealistic. This suggests that it is time to ask: What exactly are we trying to achieve? Is the primary objective employability, innovation, technology transfer, entrepreneurship, regional economic development, or workforce readiness? Different goals re-

quire different models of collaboration. A single framework cannot serve every discipline or institution.

The second question is how we incentivise companies to collaborate with universities. Industry cannot be expected to collaborate simply because policymakers encourage it. Companies invest time and resources when they perceive clear value; through access to talent, cutting-edge research, intellectual property, or competitiveness.

Finally, the most practical question of all: if deep industry collaboration cannot realistically reach every student, how should universities prepare graduates for successful careers? Perhaps the answer lies less in attempting to replicate industry inside the university and more in developing graduates who can learn quickly after entering the workforce.

The future belongs to graduates who possess strong analytical ability, excellent communication skills, teamwork, intellectual humility, ethical judgement, and the capacity for lifelong learning. Technical knowledge will matter, but the ability to continuously acquire new knowledge may matter more. Industry-academia collaboration should certainly be expanded wherever it creates genuine value. It remains indispensable for research-intensive universities, innovation ecosystems, and technology-driven sectors. However, it should not become the sole measure of educational quality or institutional

success.

The future of higher education will depend not merely on increasing the quantity of collaboration between universities and industry, but on designing models that are realistic, scalable, and aligned with the needs of both. Perhaps the time has come to stop asking how universities can become more like industry and, instead, ask a more fundamental question: What kind of graduates does society need, and what is the most practical way to prepare them?

Views are personal

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Thapar Institute of Engineering and Technology.

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OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am in Class 12 (Humanities) and plan to pursue B.A. (Hons) Political Science at Delhi University. I am interested in geopolitics, national security, and strategic studies. Are there entry-level roles after graduation, or will I need a Master's? Name withheld

While you can be hired as a programme/research assistant, research intern, or corporate risk analyst after a Bachelor's degree, a Master's in International Relations, Strategic Studies, or Public Policy is generally required to become a policy analyst or strategic advisor. A Ph.D. is highly valued in security think tanks, but less critical if you pivot to corporate strategic risk.

New Delhi is the epicentre of think tanks and corporate firms. Strategic and defence think-tanks include MP-IDSA, ORF, Carnegie India, CSEP, and CSDR. They offer internships, although postgraduate qualifications are often preferred. CAPS, CLAWS, and NMF occasionally take civilian interns to assist military fellows.

Geopolitical risk consultancies such as Control Risks, Eurasia Group, Sibylline, and S-RM hire analysts to monitor threat landscapes, political stability, and security risks for international businesses. The big Management consultancies have government and public sector advisory wings. Large global tech firms hire trust and safety or global intelligence analysts to track geopolitical events affecting operations.

I am a first-year BHMS

Prepare with confidence

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

student but am wondering if this is the right choice. Should I attempt NEET again? I like treating patients but have no confidence that I will succeed in being a physician. Azja

Dear Azja,

What is your belief regarding homoeopathy vs allopathy? If you believe that you can only be a medical doctor by doing MBBS and that homoeopathy does not feel right for you, consider taking NEET again. But if your lack of confidence stems from a general fear of diagnosing patients, making high-stakes clinical diagnoses, or interacting with the sick, MBBS comes with even higher clinical pressure, heavier emergency duties, and intense competition for post-graduation (NEET PG). Talk to your current batchmates who are probably going through something similar.

Consider completing your BHMS and then pivot to clinical research. Also explore Hospital Operations and Administration through an MBA in Healthcare Management.

You can also consider a Master's in Public Health, Pharmacovigilance, Health Insurance, or Medical Analytics.

I have finished BCA and plan to pursue a career in cricket. But I am also highly motivated to prepare for the UPSC. I want to have a strong backup but am confused about whether to pursue a

Master's or an LLB. Which degree will give me time and flexibility to focus on cricket and UPSC? Is there any other option? Tejas

Dear Tejas,

Cricket and UPSC require extreme focus and huge blocks of uninterrupted time. Cricket demands hours of physical training, field presence, and extensive travel for matches, while UPSC requires massive discipline, consistency, and analytical reading.

Choosing a Master's in a subject that doubles as your UPSC Optional Subject, such as Public Administration, Political Science, History, or Geography, can help.

If you choose distance education through universities such as IGNOU, attendance pressure is almost negligible. A low-residency Master's could also give you time for cricket nets and tournaments.

LL.B. will not offer the same flexibility. The Bar Council of India mandates minimum attendance requirements for regular LL.B. courses. A legal degree also requires regular moot courts, internships, and intensive semester exams. But this is a professional qualification that allows you to work independently in litigation or enter corporate law.

If your options do not work, you will be in your mid-to-late 20s when you enter the job market. An MCA builds directly upon your BCA foundation and can lead to software engineering, systems architecture and data management roles.

Your decision rests on what you want to prioritise right now.

I graduated in Mechanical Engineering in 2022 and have been preparing for competitive exams, but I haven't cracked any. I have no idea what to do next and don't want to depend on my family. How can I get a job? Adithya

Dear Adithya,

You are conditioned to think that your worth is tied to clearing a massive exam. It isn't. The industry doesn't care about your exam scores; it cares if you can solve a problem today. Dust yourself off, change your direction, and start moving.

You already have a four-year gap. What are you waiting for now? Break the cycle, stop depending on your family, and build a meaningful career. A 'meaningful' job should simply pay you an independent salary.

Do not look for ultimate purpose in your first job after a gap. You will find meaning from earning your own money and contributing at home. Once financially secure, you can map out a larger corporate trajectory.

Corporate recruiters may hesitate about gaps because they fear your skills have rusted. Reframe your last four years' experience. Consider short-term certifications in HVAC/MEP Design or Piping Design and Engineering, with opportunities in manufacturing, infrastructure, data centres, oil, gas and power.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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17th CONVOCATION

CELEBRATING ACHIEVEMENTS

Hindustan Institute of Technology & Science Hosts 17th Convocation; 2,732 Students Awarded Degrees

Chennai, 19 September 2026: Hindustan Institute of Technology & Science (HITS) successfully hosted its 17th Convocation Ceremony, conferring degrees on 2,732 graduating students and marking a significant milestone in their academic journey.

The ceremony was graced by Justice M.M. Sundresh, Judge, Supreme Court of India, as Chief Guest, with Ambassador Akhilesh Mishra, IFS; Mr. Gokul V. Subramaniam, President, Intel India; Dr. K.M. Suceendran, Head – Alliances Group, TCS; and Dr. Oscar Concessao, Architect, Oscar, Ponni, Rahul Architects as Guests of Honour.

The event was presided over by Dr. Anand Jacob Verghese, Chancellor; in the presence of Dr. Ashok George Verghese, Pro Chancellor; Dr. Aby Sam, Executive Director; Mr. Enid Verghese Jacob, Associate Director; and Dr. Vikas Misra, Vice Chancellor.

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2,732 Total Degrees Awarded	2,006 Undergraduate Students	659 Postgraduate Students	67 Ph.D. Students	92 Rank Holders	27 Foreign Nationals
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Dr. Oscar Concessao
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in recognition of their distinguished contributions and achievements in their respective fields.

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Hindustan Centre for Future Skills (HCFS) was inaugurated by Hon'ble Justice M. M. Sundresh. Established in collaboration with NSDC and Ethnotech Academy, HCFS bridge the gap between academic learning and industry expectations, the Centre provides students with access to state-of-the-art technology infrastructure, industry-led training and globally recognised certifications.

The Centre focuses on emerging and high-demand domains such as Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning, Data Analytics, Cloud Computing, Cyber Security, Internet of Things (IoT), Augmented and Virtual Reality (AR/VR), Robotic Process Automation, Industrial Automation and Semiconductor Design. The objective of the Centre for Future Skills is to empower students to excel in an increasingly technology-driven world while enhancing their employability, innovation capabilities and readiness for the careers of tomorrow.

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CM YK

From Page One

T.N. government rescinds order exempting Public Department from RTI Act

The Public (Law and Order) Department deals with subjects such as communal and caste clashes; the appointment of Commissions of Inquiry into law and order matters and follow-up action on their recommendations; all matters relating to CO-FEPOSA and NSA detentions, including representations by detenus and *habeas corpus* petitions filed by detenus or on their behalf in the High Court and the Supreme Court; and the conduct of monthly law and order review meetings and special law and order meetings under the instructions of the Chief Secretary.

It also includes examining inquiry reports into the opening of fire by the police and inquiry reports into deaths in police custody, police torture and deaths of remand prisoners; and matters relating to sanction of prosecution for defamatory articles, news items and speeches.

Mr. Dhinakaran opposed the G.O. He criticised the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam-led government for having assured transparency in governance only to exempt sensitive subjects pertaining to law and order from the ambit of the RTI Act. Seeking an explanation from Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, he called for revoking the decision.

Mr. Sundarrajan, the environmental activist, said the timing of the order was deeply concerning. The earlier controversy over a law and order meeting chaired by Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar had already raised serious questions after the minutes of the meeting became public and drew strong opposition from the Left parties.

The government had subsequently withdrawn a controversial circular on collegiate education that had followed the directions issued at the meeting.

Mr. Jayaram Venkatesan demanded the immediate withdrawal of the order. He said the entire law and order section of the Public Department could not be kept out of the purview of the RTI Act.

Policeman risks life to nab gutkha smugglers

He immediately alerted his counterparts at the Kovilpalayam station, from where Sub-Inspector V. Vignesh and Mr. Velmurugan swung into action and intercepted the SUV at Kaikolapalayam.

As Mr. Vignesh was talking to the men in the SUV through an open window, the driver raised the glass, trapping one of his hands, and immediately reversed the SUV in a bid to escape. Mr. Velmurugan, who was holding the SUV's roof with the other hand, climbed atop the vehicle and held onto the rails. As he banged on the roof, the driver released his hand and sped away with Mr. Velmurugan on top of the vehicle.

The SUV sped through Kalapatti, Nehru Nagar junction, and airport junction to reach Avinashi Road and headed to Tiruppur on the busy Salem-Kochi Highway, often clocking over 100 kmph. Meanwhile, Mr. Vignesh chased the SUV on a private car, while Mr. Thiagarajan and his team followed in a police vehicle.

"The police immediately alerted the NHA1, which deputed an ambulance to ensure the policeman's safety. Though we had alerted the Kaniyur toll gate, the SUV got away as the boom barrier operated with the FASTag. The video of the policeman on the SUV was shot by the ambulance crew," said District Superintendent of Police A. Pavan Kumar Reddy.

The SUV was blocked with the assistance of the Avinashi police near Mangalam junction in Tiruppur district. Though the three smugglers – Babu Dhara, 27, A. Rajesh, 23, and S. Suresh, 20 – ran out of the vehicle, the police chased and arrested them, said Karikal Pari Shankar, Deputy Superintendent of Police, Karumathampatti Sub-Division. Two of them suffered fractures on their upper limbs in the escape bid.

"I got atop the SUV in an attempt to stop them. But they sped away. I clung onto the rails, determined not to give up," said Mr. Velmurugan. Mr. Velmurugan's daring action earned the praise of Tamil Nadu Ministers, police officers, and social media users.

INBRIEF

Research paper by doctors of Ganga Hospital wins award

The combined research of the spine surgery and radiology department of Ganga Hospital has won the prestigious North American Spine Society Outstanding Research Paper Award for 2026, a hospital release said on Sunday. The research was on a cutting edge specialised MRI sequence that could predict the post-operative recovery in compressions of the cervical spinal cord requiring surgery. The paper was titled 'Preoperative Metabolite Ratio Improves Prediction of Post Operative Recovery in Degenerative Cervical Myelopathy: A Prospective Cohort Study' The research was carried out by R. Karthik, Ajoy Shetty, Pushpa B.T., HariKrishna, Swathika, Rishi Kanna, and S. Rajasekaran. The award will be presented during the 41st Annual Meeting of the North American Spine Society in San Antonio, Texas, U.S., on October 15. This is the fifth time the hospital has won the award, the release added.

E.V. Velu, others booked for illegal excavation of lake bed to level venue for party event

Approximately 45,72,058 cubic feet of lake-bed sand was alleged to have been transported from about 8 acres of the waterbody, resulting in an estimated loss of ₹8.22 crore to the T.N. exchequer

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) has registered a case against E.V. Velu, DMK MLA and formerly Minister for Highways, Minor Ports, and Public Works, his son E.V. Kumaran, other public servants, and contractors, among others on charges of unauthorised excavation of lake-bed material in Malappambadi village in Tiruvannamalai district for levelling the venue of a DMK Northern Zone Youth Wing Conference held in December 2025.

The case was registered on the basis of a complaint lodged by Jayaram Venkatesan, convener, Arappor Iyakkam.

The allegation is that Mr. Velu misused his official position and facilitated excavation and removal of lake-bed material from Malappambadi Lake, covering about 12 acres.

The material was excavated to a depth of about



E.V. Velu

10-23 feet from November 2025 to the first week of December 2025, for levelling the conference venue, with the active connivance of the Revenue, Collectorate, Corporation, and other officials concerned.

Around 45,72,058 cubic feet of lake-bed sand was alleged to have been transported from about 8 acres of the lake, resulting in an estimated loss of ₹8.22 crore to the exchequer.

It was also alleged that an approach road was illegally expanded and laid over and through the tank bund and foreshore area of the Malappambadi Lake up

A verification exercise by officials confirmed that unauthorised excavation of soil and gravel had occurred within the lake, corroborating the allegations

to the entrance gate of the family property of Mr. Velu, where the conference was conducted.

Permission was not obtained from the Revenue Department, Corporation, or Geology and Mining Department, Tiruvannamalai District, for the excavation and removal of gravel/lake-bed material from the waterbody.

During the verification conducted with the assistance of the Revenue and Geology and Mining Department officials concerned, unauthorised excavation/mining of soil and gravel was found at various locations within the lake area, thereby corroborat-

ing the allegation of illegal excavation.

'No effective action'

In November 2025, Arul Arumugam, a former office-bearer of an organisation, submitted petitions to the district authorities alleging illegal excavation. However, no effective action was initiated to stop the excavation, ascertain the extent of unauthorised extraction, identify the persons responsible, or initiate appropriate proceedings.

Despite information and complaints regarding the unauthorised excavation, the officials failed to take effective action.

"Such deliberate and wilful inaction, despite knowledge of the illegal excavation, *prima facie* indicates connivance with the persons involved and intentional failure to discharge their statutory duties, thereby facilitating and enabling the illegal excavation and removal of lake-bed material," the DVAC said in its FIR.

State government steps up support for enterprises headed by women

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government hopes to expand women's participation in entrepreneurship and economic activity through the 'Vetri Magalir Thozhil-munaivor Membattu Thittam', providing accessible institutional finance to eligible women aspiring to start and grow their own enterprises. The idea is to ensure women have access to the capital and institutional support required to turn their entrepreneurial aspirations into viable businesses.

Access to capital

"There are thousands of women across Tamil Nadu with the ambition, ability, and determination to build their own enterprises, but access to capital can often be the barrier between an idea and a business. The Vetri Magalir Thozhil-munaivor Membattu Thittam is designed to help bridge that gap," said S. Keerthana, Minister for Industries and Investment Promotion.

Stating women's economic empowerment must be an integral part of Tamil Nadu's next phase of industrial and economic growth, she said, "Every successful woman-led enterprise can create opportunities for other women and strengthen the local economy around it."

Loans up to ₹5 crore

Under the scheme, eligible women entrepreneurs can avail themselves of loans ranging from ₹10 lakh to ₹5 crore through the Tamil Nadu Industrial Investment Corporation (TIIC).

The loans are offered at an interest rate of 9.95% per annum on a diminishing balance basis, with a repayment period of up to nine years. The Industries Department is taking the scheme to all 234 Assembly constituencies of Tamil Nadu.

MLAs have been requested to identify 10 promising women from their respective constituencies. The applications will subsequently be examined based on eligibility and merit.

Vijaya Prabhakaran to withdraw election petition against TNCC chief's 2024 LS win

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

DMDK youth wing secretary V. Vijaya Prabhakaran has decided to withdraw an election petition filed by him before the Madras High Court in 2024 challenging the victory of Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president B. Manickam Tagore in the Virudhunagar Lok Sabha constituency.

In an application filed before Justice N. Sathish Kumar, Mr. Prabhakaran said he did not want to take the election petition for trial since he had decided to pay attention to public life rather than continuing the litigation pending for the last two years. He sought the leave of the court, under Sections 109 and 110 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, to withdraw the election petition.

The judge has directed the applicant to issue notice to all the parties to the election petition, besides

issuing a publication in the official government gazette expressing his desire to withdraw the election petition to find out if any other eligible person was interested in substituting for the election petitioner in order to continue the challenge to the victory of Mr. Tagore, the Virudhunagar MP.

Three-cornered fight

The Virudhunagar Lok Sabha constituency had witnessed a three-cornered fight between Mr. Tagore, Mr. Prabhakaran and actor R. Radikaa Sarathkumar of the BJP.

In his election petition, Mr. Prabhakaran had accused IAS officer V.P. Jeya-seelan, the Returning Officer for Virudhunagar, of having succumbed to the pressure exerted by the then DMK Ministers, K.K.S.S.R. Ramachandran, Thangam Thennarasu, and P. Moorthy, for furthering the prospects of the election of Mr. Tagore, the candidate of their then ally.

Ex-Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi moves HC to quash FIR in fraud case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Former School Education Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) has approached the Madras High Court with a plea to quash a First Information Report (FIR) registered by the Chennai Central Crime Branch (CCB) police on June 27, 2026 in connection with the alleged illegal collection of over ₹100 crore from various private schools in the State during the erstwhile DMK regime.

Justice V. Lakshminarayana would be hearing on Monday a sub application filed by him to dispense with the production of original copy of the FIR. The CCB had booked the FIR against the president of an unregistered association of private schools B.T. Arasakumar and his alleged accomplices following a complaint lodged by D.C. Elangovan, president of a registered association.

In his complaint to the Greater Chennai Commis-



Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi

sioner of Police A. Amalraj on June 23, 2026, Mr. Elangovan had alleged the prime accused, by claiming to be close to the ruling dispensation, had collected crores of rupees from the managements of various private schools for offering services such as obtaining approvals for upgrading schools, gaining permanent recognition, and securing building plan approvals.

Listing the names of 13 other individuals – Muthukumar, G.R. Sridhar, Palaniappan, Chandrasekaran, Dinesh, Einstein, Subbiah, Suba alias Subramaniam, Suseendran, Deivasigamani, Senniappan, Janaga-

rathinam and 'Bank' Subramaniam – as the accomplices of the prime accused, the complainant had urged the police to probe into the role played by the former Minister too and initiate appropriate action.

Custodial interrogation

Pursuant to the complaint, the CCB had arrested the prime accused on June 27 and subjected him to custodial interrogation.

Thereafter, he was detained under the Goondas Act on July 11 and his wife had challenged the preventive detention before the High Court by way of a habeas corpus petition. She claimed a civil dispute between office-bearers of two associations had been given a criminal colour.

As part of their investigation, the CCB sleuths went ahead and conducted searches at nine places connected to Mr. Poyyamozhi in Chennai as well as Tiruchi on September 16 besides summoning him for inquiry on September 18.

'Confident that Vijay will accept Rahul as PM candidate'

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee (TNCC) president B. Manickam Tagore has expressed hope that TVK president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will also endorse Congress leader Rahul Gandhi as the INDIA bloc's Prime Ministerial candidate for the Lok Sabha polls in 2029.

In an interview with *The Hindu*, he exuded confidence that Mr. Vijay would make such an announcement ahead of the Parliamentary election.

When pointed out that the TVK's second-line leaders were already projecting Mr. Vijay as the "future Prime Minister", he said

such slogans were no longer being raised. "A few people in the party were expressing their personal wish. They are not talking about it now. When the elections arrive, the TVK chief will announce who they are supporting. The Tamil Nadu Congress will contest the elections projecting Rahul Gandhi, and I am 100% confident that Mr. Vijay will support it," Mr. Tagore said.

According to him, the DMK, which exited the INDIA bloc after the Congress joined the TVK-led Ministry post-Assembly polls, will not win in the Lok Sabha elections even if it forms a [national-level] third front. "Didn't they contest alone in 2014? How many



B. Manickam Tagore

seats did they win? The exact same thing will happen now. They talk about forming a third front; their wish will be fulfilled in the byelections – they will only get the third place," he said.

Mr. Tagore believed the DMK's exit has not weakened the Opposition in

any way at the national level. "People claimed that the Opposition wouldn't be able to achieve anything during this Parliamentary session. Yet, we did not let the session run. As far as we are concerned, all 23 members of the INDIA bloc remain ideologically united," Mr. Tagore said.

Chances of a third front

He felt movements such as the Cockroach Janta Party might exist as a phenomena for sometime, but the chances of a real third front emerging are slim. He alleged that the BJP manufactured stories about third fronts purely to split the Opposition votes.

When asked whether the TVK would be aggres-

sive in taking on the BJP, Mr. Tagore responded: "TVK is a young party. As far as they are concerned, they stand with us on issues such as delimitation. Furthermore, in Tamil Nadu, there is a Secular Social Justice Victory Alliance. Whenever the BJP acts against Tamil Nadu, this alliance will collectively decide the course of action. I am confident they will stand with us on the protest ground."

Questioned about the TVK's silence on several national issues, he justified it saying, "Everyone has their own style. You cannot expect someone to prove themselves every single day or issue press statements daily."



Serious claim: The BJP has accused the Congress govt. of lacking commitment to help drought-hit farmers in the State. ARUN KULKARNI

BJP, JD(S) opt out of Karnataka delegation on drought relief

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Janata Dal (Secular) have refused to be part of the proposed all-party delegation planned by the Karnataka government to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek Central assistance for drought relief.

On Sunday, Union Minister and JD(S) leader H.D. Kumaraswamy and Leader of the Opposition in the Legislative Assembly R. Ashok said that they would not be part of the proposed delegation.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar is leaving for Delhi on Monday to take part in the Congress Working Committee meeting scheduled for Tuesday.

Mr. Kumaraswamy said the State representatives could go on their own, and that there was no need for an all-party delegation.

Mr. Shivakumar, at the end of the four-day special session convened to discuss the drought, farm distress, and the Kasturirangan Committee report, announced that an all-par-

Karnataka is seeking a meeting between PM and an all-party delegation regarding drought relief: CM

ty delegation would be taken to Mr. Modi to seek Central assistance in drought mitigation efforts.

‘Unnecessary expense’
“What will you do by taking an all-party delegation to the Centre? It will add to the expenditure of the exchequer. Spending on flights and stay in star-category hotels is an unnecessary expenditure. Could someone not go and speak to the Centre?” the Union Minister told presspersons on Sunday. Stating he would not say that the State has gone bankrupt, he said, “It is you who has been sitting on an empty treasury.”

Meanwhile, Mr. Ashok said they would not go to the Centre to seek funds for drought relief.

“We are ready to meet the Union Minister over the Kasturirangan report,” he added.

ED report alone can’t be basis for FIR in CMRL case: Minister

The agency has sought FIR against Pinarayi, daughter, and son-in-law; Home Minister says Kerala govt. decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry as there was lack of clarity on certain aspects

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Sunday said that an FIR cannot be lodged against Leader of the Opposition and Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and her husband and CPI(M) State secretariat member P.A. Mohamed Riyas merely on the basis of a proposal from the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The agency has alleged that the CMRL made fraudulent payments of ₹2.78 crore to Ms. Veena’s now-



State’s stand: Inquiry was ordered based on Advocate-General’s advice in the CMRL pay-off case, said Ramesh Chennithala. H. VIBHU

defunct company, Exalogic Solutions, under the guise of “IT consultancy services”.

The ED had sought registration of a case based on “evidence” gathered during its probe and searches conducted under

the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

Mr. Chennithala told presspersons that the State government recently ordered a preliminary inquiry into the issue based on the legal advice it received. “The government is not

opposed to registering an FIR in the case. But we decided to first conduct a preliminary inquiry based on the Advocate-General’s advice as there was a lack of clarity on certain things,” he said.

High Court directive

He said that the government had placed its stand in the Kerala High Court.

The High Court, on Saturday, directed the ED to submit the records it had provided to the Kerala Police while recommending registration of a case against Mr. Vijayan and his family. The court will hear the matter next on September 29. (With inputs from PTI)

Keralam CM calls for CEC’s resignation

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam Chief Minister V. D. Satheesan on Sunday joined the growing chorus of political leaders demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

In a statement, Mr. Satheesan said that former Chief Secretary Jiji Thomson’s revelation that Mr. Kumar had sought to persuade him to join the BJP and contest on the party ticket from the Pathanamthitta Lok Sabha consti-

tuency in 2019 has raised worrying questions about the Election Commission’s political even-handedness and neutrality.

“Mr. Kumar has operated recurrently as the BJP’s agent, compromising the EC’s public credibility. He has lost the moral and constitutional right to continue in office and should step down immediately,” Mr. Satheesan said.

‘Risk to democracy’

Mr. Satheesan alleged that Mr. Kumar had tethered the EC to the BJP’s post and made the constitutional

election watchdog an appendage of the Sangh Parishad. “His continuation in the EC would further imperil India’s already flailing democracy,” he said.

Mr. Satheesan’s statement seemed to assume political and constitutional significance against the backdrop of allegations Mr. Kumar had overruled two Election Commissioners to exclude lakhs of people, chiefly those hailing from minority communities and marginalised sections of society, from the electoral rolls to stack the decks in favour of the BJP in As-

sembly and Lok Sabha elections.

Mr. Thomson told *The Hindu* on Sunday that Mr. Kumar had made a friendly suggestion, not an offer, when sharing a flight to New Delhi.

However, the ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Opposition touted Mr. Thomson’s statement as more definitive proof of Mr. Kumar “subverting the EC to rig the electoral system in favour of the pro-corporate and Hindu nationalist dispensation at the Centre”.

INBRIEF



CJP opens chapter in Keralam; receives 20,000 registrations

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) is keen to expand its base in Keralam even as it stepped up campaign for resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision. The CJP has received about 20,000 registrations, the highest from any State, said CJP national media lead Vijay Reddy Mallangi. At a meet attended by about 150 supporters in Kochi, he questioned the BJP for defending the CEC. People from different age groups attended the meet, said to be the CJP’s first official one in the State.

Three suspects detained in A.P. over woman’s murder

Nearly 10 days after a woman’s body parts were found in a canal in Andhra Pradesh’s NTR district, the police have taken three suspects into custody. The police recovered the dismembered body from the VTPS cooling canal in Ibrahimpatnam on September 18. After going through ‘woman missing’ cases in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, the police identified the victim as 28-year-old Kalyani Durga from Mangalagiri. The police say the victim was in a relationship with a mutton shop owner and had quarrelled with him a day before she was killed.

KSRTC to run more inter-State services for festival season

The Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) has announced special inter-State services to accommodate the travel rush associated with Mahanavami, Vijayadashami and Diwali celebrations. From October 14 to November 14, additional buses will operate between cities such as Bengaluru, Mysuru and Chennai, and various locations in Keralam. Online reservation facilities have already been launched, allowing passengers to book tickets in advance without hassle.

Keralam Minister defends using luxury car as official vehicle

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

Keralam Minister for Local Self-Governments and Indian Union Muslim League leader K.M. Shaji has again defended his use of a luxury car with a State government registration plate, accusing news media of lapping up a controversy created by the “cyber wing” of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)].

Mr. Shaji told presspersons on Sunday that his photo being circulated on social media, which showed him leaning on the car, was created by using artificial intelligence. He

said a Minister need not use only a government vehicle. The rule says that it should have a tricolour.

“The vehicle being used by a Minister is the Minister’s vehicle, and it can be a private one... The only issue is that we should not grant any favours in return,” Mr. Shaji said, adding that the rules would have to be “changed” if someone wanted to put him in the dock.

Mr. Shaji had come under criticism for affixing the State government registration plate, Keralam State 13, reserved for the official vehicles of Ministers, on a privately owned luxury vehicle.

Hanging home



Rare sight: A baya weaver (*Ploceus philippinus*) enters its nest on a palm tree in Palakkad, Keralam. Once commonly seen here, the bird and its distinctive nests are now rare, owing to changes in agricultural land-use patterns and environmental degradation. K.K. MUSTAFAH

A.P. announces promotions; Secretariat staff seek pay hike

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh government has issued orders enabling promotions for four categories of Swarna Ward Secretariat functionaries following the recent approval by the State Cabinet.

The order covers Ward Administrative Secretaries, Ward Data Processing Secretaries, Ward Sanitation and Environment Secretaries (Grade-II), and Ward Planning and Regulation Secretaries (Grade-II).

A.P. Village and Ward Secretariat Government Employees’ Association State president Sheik Abdul Rajak, who was detained at a police station throughout the day, told



Employees of Village and Ward Secretariats staging a protest in Vijayawada on Sunday. K.V.S. GIRI

The Hindu that the Government Order (G.O.), issued by the Municipal Administration and Urban Development Department on Sunday, was only a token gesture and would not benefit employees much.

“The promotions do not

lead to more than ₹2,000 increments for us. What use are the promotions if our salaries are not increased from the current ₹25,500 to ₹30,000?” he questioned.

Longstanding issue

The decision addresses a longstanding issue affecting employees recruited in 2019, many of whom have completed more than six years of service without receiving a promotion despite the promotional hierarchy having been notified by the government.

The decision is expected to benefit eligible employees working across Swarna Ward Secretariats functioning in the Urban Local Bodies.

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

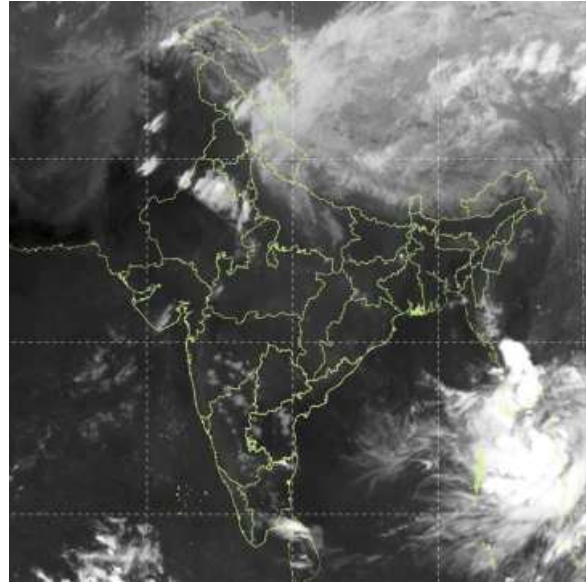
Researchers have identified a new species of the genus *Begonia* from the Western Ghats region in Kollam district of Keralam.

A research team of the Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute (JNTBGRI) in Thiruvananthapuram spotted the plant during an exploration for collecting wild ornamental plants from the evergreen forests of Rosemala in Kollam.

The discovery has been reported at a time when the ghats region is back in the news in connection with the State government’s recommendations regarding Ecologically Sensitive Areas (ESA).

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Karnataka and Uttarakhand. Thundersquall with wind speed reaching 50-60kmph very likely at isolated places over Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	—	35.1	26.2	Kurnool	—	36.0	25.1
Ahmedabad	—	34.7	25.0	Lucknow	—	36.0	24.0
Aizawl	4.0	31.5	21.4	Madurai	—	39.5	25.6
Bengaluru	—	31.3	20.2	Mangaluru	—	30.1	22.7
Bhopal	—	—	22.2	Mumbai	0.4	32.1	26.0
Bhubaneswar	2.1	33.6	24.6	Mysuru	—	30.8	18.8
Chandigarh	—	30.4	22.2	New Delhi	4.0	30.2	21.2
Chennai	—	36.7	27.2	Patna	—	61.2	32.0
Coimbatore	—	34.8	21.6	Port Blair	—	29.9	29.9
Dehradun	24.6	18.4	21.1	Prayagraj	—	14.3	29.4
Gangtok	—	24.2	16.7	Puducherry	—	37.1	37.1
Goa	—	—	—	Pune	—	32.0	22.3
Guwahati	—	34.2	25.4	Raipur	—	31.0	31.0
Hubballi	—	32.0	19.0	Ranchi	—	33.0	29.3
Hyderabad	—	33.3	23.4	Shillong	—	24.0	24.0
Imphal	—	33.3	21.7	Shimla	—	24.2	16.0
Jaipur	—	22.7	—	Srinagar	—	29.8	29.8
Kochi	—	31.2	25.8	Thiruvananthapuram	—	32.4	32.4
Kohima	7.0	25.0	18.3	Tiruchirappalli	—	38.5	38.5
Kolkata	3.1	32.4	26.8	Vijayawada	—	—	—
Kozhikode	—	35.0	24.9	Visakhapatnam	—	33.0	26.5

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	15	17	8	56	102	—	In observation made at 4.00 p.m.,
Bengaluru	27	63	43	62	120	—	Gummidipoondi, Tamil
Chennai	43	10	15	43	97	—	Nadu recorded an overall
Delhi	—	—	—	—	—	—	air quality index (AQI)
Hyderabad	13	23	52	54	98	—	score of 174 indicating an
Kolkata	9	20	34	51	72	—	unhealthy level of
Lucknow	10	25	15	15	28	—	pollution. In contrast,
Mumbai	3	17	13	41	93	—	Madikeri, Karnataka
Pune	—	31	65	35	72	—	recorded a healthy AQI
Visakhapatnam	10	62	6	79	137	—	score of 15.

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease



Begonia rajvikramanii

They named the species *Begonia rajvikramanii* after R. Raj Vikraman, former Head of the Garden Management Division, JNTBGRI, in recognition of his contributions to the development of the JNTBGRI

garden and the management of ex-situ plant conservation programmes at the institute.

A paper on the discovery and the plant’s identification as a new species by E.S. Santhosh Kumar, S.M. Shareef, P.P. Anusha and Rejitha Joseph of JNTBGRI has been published in the latest issue of *Phytotaxa*.

The plant was found growing on wet rocky cliffs. “This new species is currently known only from its type locality at Rosemala. It grows in wet habitats, particularly on rocky cliffs and road-cut walls, at elevations of approximately 200 metres-350 metres,” the paper said.

Its flowering and fruiting occurs between August and April.



India's institutions have largely held except in dark periods such as the Emergency, when an executive emboldened by legislative strength ran roughshod over the Constitution and a shamelessly permissive judiciary let it do so via *ADM Jabalpur*. The ECI under Mr. Kumar has overseen the removal of more than 13 crore names from draft rolls through the SIR which, as this daily has repeatedly argued, shifts the onus of enrolment from the state to the elector, deletes names before it verifies and imposes onerous conditions for re-entry. It got away with this because the Supreme Court declined for months to decide whether the exercise was constitutional. When it finally ruled on May 27, the SIR was already a settled fact in Bihar, West Bengal and other Phase 2 States. The judgment, reminiscent of *ADM Jabalpur*'s deference to the state, engaged the SIR in theory and not in practice. It read a provision for exceptional, targeted revisions as a licence for a State-wide sweep. While it assured voters already on the rolls that they were still presumed eligible, the SIR made them prove it all over again. And it brushed aside its 1995 ruling that every removal must be individually reasoned. Events since then indicate the damage done – over nine in 10 appeals decided by West Bengal's tribunals have restored voters months after the Assembly polls; and in one third of Delhi's seats, the draft rolls have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025. The ECI's press note changes very little. The ECI must be reconstituted by a selection committee that does not give the government an overriding majority. Anything less would be a travesty of institutional democracy.

As the U.S. and China recalibrate ties, implications for other nations are huge

The model outcomes from the Xi visit should not obscure the broader shift that recent U.S.-China engagement has underlined. The agreement between the world's two biggest powers to pursue what they call a constructive relationship of strategic stability based on fairness, respect and reciprocity points to a new equilibrium. Their relationship certainly remains beset by serious structural challenges and will remain one marked by rivalry. At the same time, both sides appear eager to set a floor to ensure a rivalry that is more managed, stable and predictable. Countries in the region will be watching closely how this may temper an "America First" Washington's appetite to push back against China in waters far from home. New Delhi will need to carefully watch this evolving new equilibrium. The recent U.S. tariff threats aimed at India have offered a stark contrast to the measured language with which Washington has been engaging Beijing. For long, a strand of Indian strategic thinking has been predicated on the assumption that U.S. strategy in the region was centred on the idea of a relationship with India as a bulwark against Chinese influence. That assumption increasingly appears open to question.

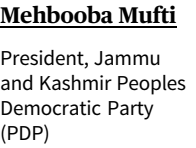
The aspiration-reality gap

The smartphone revolution has intensified this challenge. A young person in a town or remote village can now see within seconds how the rest of the world lives, studies, works and travels. Global possibilities are visible on high-definition screens, even as tangible opportunities remain painfully out of reach.

This has created a widening divide between aspiration and reality. The horizons of young Indians have expanded far faster than the institutions and economies around them. Access to higher education has widened, yet meaningful employment opportunities have not kept pace. A college degree is no longer a guarantee of a job, leaving many without financial security or the dignity that comes with economic independence. When heightened aspirations collide with limited opportunities, frustration inevitably follows, often finding expression in protests over recruitment, examination irregularities, examination and test paper leaks, unemployment and systemic failures.

Kashmiri youth share these aspirations but carry a compounding historical burden. Decades of conflict, political uncertainty and economic isolation have deepened their sense of insecurity and constrained their opportunities. Too often, young Kashmiris have been viewed through a narrow security lens, as potential liabilities rather than national assets.

Yet, Jammu and Kashmir, like the rest of India, has a large young population with its own aspirations. Its youth seek the same basic things as young people elsewhere: economic



Reconnecting Kashmir's historic routes could unlock economic opportunities for its youth

independence, dignity, opportunity and a future in which they are not permanently viewed with suspicion.

Jammu and Kashmir possesses an exceptional combination of natural wealth and geographic significance. Its rivers offer substantial hydroelectric potential, its mountains contain valuable mineral resources, and its landscapes sustain a major tourism economy. Yet, its most underutilised strategic asset may be its location

Focus on Kashmir's historic crossroads

For centuries, Kashmir was never a cul-de-sac. It was a thriving crossroads. Historic caravan routes linked Kashmir and Ladakh with Central Asia, Tibet and the broader Indian subcontinent. These routes carried far more than merchandise. They connected people, ideas, philosophies, literature, cultures and skills. The arrival of Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani, revered as Shah-i-Hamadani, is deeply embedded in Kashmiri history and is traditionally associated with the arrival of Persian and Central Asian craftsmen who enriched Kashmir's celebrated handicraft traditions. The historical lesson is clear: connectivity creates economic ecosystems.

Today, Indian strategic thinking needs to look beyond the immediate constraints posed by the Line of Control with Pakistan and the Line of Actual Control with China. Where political and security conditions permit, India needs a pragmatic framework to gradually restore Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh to the role they historically occupied: that of a bridge connecting South Asia with Central Asia and the wider Eurasian landmass.

For this, India needs a diplomatic road map alongside its infrastructure road map. Reopening traditional routes towards Pakistan or Central Asia cannot happen without sustained engagement with neighbouring countries. With Pakistan, the objective should be to explore confidence-building measures and trade connectivity wherever feasible. With China, India should pursue practical dialogue on trans-Himalayan connectivity wherever economic interests and security concerns can be reconciled.

This transition could begin with a phased connectivity strategy. India should identify historically important trade corridors that could eventually be revived as modern economic corridors, beginning with those where security and diplomatic conditions are most conducive. This does not mean opening every route at once.

G. Venkat Raman
Professor, Humanities
and Social Sciences,
Indian Institute of
Management, Indore,
Madhya Pradesh

De-Sinification is reshaping factories, but industrial ecosystems remain harder to move

competitiveness of companies such as BYD and Xpeng rests partly on dense networks of component makers, engineering capabilities and production relationships developed within China. Moving a factory abroad therefore creates a choice: take existing suppliers along, cultivate new local suppliers, or combine the two. Each route carries different costs – and produces a different degree of genuine localisation.

The challenge beyond factories

BYD's expansion in Europe illustrates one response. As it builds manufacturing capacity in Hungary, the company is also developing relationships with European suppliers. Xpeng has chosen another route, contracting Canadian automotive supplier Magna to assemble its vehicles in Austria. The two approaches differ, but they expose the same underlying problem: producing outside China is easier than reproducing outside China, the ecosystem that made production in China efficient in the first place.

What makes these ecosystems difficult to unwind or reproduce is that they consist of more than identifiable suppliers. They embody accumulated relationships between firms, specialised skills, tooling and production knowledge, logistics networks, and the ability of suppliers to respond quickly when designs or production volumes change. Many of these advantages are built through repeated interaction rather than formal contracts. This is why replacing an individual Chinese supplier does not necessarily eliminate dependence on the wider Chinese production system – and why transplanting a Chinese factory abroad does not automatically transplant the capabilities surrounding it.

Seen from this perspective, de-Sinification has a less obvious, two-sided character. Foreign firms attempting to reduce their exposure to China confront the depth of China's integration into their production networks. Chinese firms going global confront the difficulty of reproducing abroad the ecosystem on which their competitiveness depends. One side is trying to

Pilot corridors could be developed and expanded progressively on the basis of experience.

Security cannot be ignored in any such endeavour. But security and connectivity need not automatically be treated as opposing objectives. Properly regulated connectivity can create greater economic interdependence and potentially provide stronger incentives for stability.

The same principle should guide India's approach to Central Asia. Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh could become India's northern economic gateway, giving Indian businesses greater access to Central Asian markets while bringing investment, tourism and commerce to the region. The benefits would extend far beyond Kashmir.

A road to opportunity

A functioning land corridor creates opportunities at every stage, from construction, transport and warehousing to hospitality, manufacturing, agriculture, logistics, finance, technology and services. Unlike air connectivity, whose economic benefits are concentrated around a limited number of nodes, a trade corridor can generate economic activity across a wider geography through which it passes.

Most importantly, it could give the young people of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh something far more valuable than another promise. It could give them wings to fly towards new horizons.

India's demographic advantage is a window of opportunity, not a permanent condition. We cannot afford to allow a generation to grow up watching possibilities on smartphones while encountering closed doors in the real world.

For Jammu and Kashmir, the answer may lie partly in reopening doors that history once kept open. The Silk Road was never only about silk. It was about the movement of goods, people, ideas and possibilities.

It is time to view Kashmir not merely through the prism of conflict, but through the lens of enterprise, connectivity and integration. Former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee spoke of abandoning beaten paths and searching for new ways to address difficult issues. The ancient roads across the Himalayas do not belong merely in history books. Reimagined as modern economic arteries, they could become pathways to opportunity, giving the next generation not another reason to wait, but a road towards a better future.

A credibility crisis

The Election Commission of India (ECI)'s decision to undertake a special drive to help those left out of the SIR and make changes in its functioning is clearly a response to the investigation by The Indian Express and the brickbats that followed from the Opposition. But it would be premature to see this as a change of heart. The ECI's handling of various issues so far has raised serious

questions about its independence and sensitivity to public concerns. As a constitutional body, it was expected to function with the fierce independence seen during T.N. Seshan's tenure. Instead, a widespread perception prevails that it has become vulnerable to political pressures. As a septuagenarian voter who values honesty and sincerity, I find it deeply

troubling that such independent institutions respond more to those in power than to the Constitution, their conscience and the collective will of the citizens.

V. Nagarajan,
Chennai

The reported dissent of two Election Commissioners over the functioning of the electoral-roll revision process raises serious

questions about the working of the electoral machinery. Concerns over ERONet access, changes to Form 6 and the exclusion of eligible voters cannot be treated lightly. Yet, recording dissent alone cannot end the responsibility of constitutional functionaries. If such irregularities were considered serious, the Commissioners ought to have pursued the available institutional mechanisms to

seek their resolution. Their failure to do so also raises questions about accountability within the institution entrusted with protecting the integrity of the electoral process.

Kanhaiya Pandey,
Giridih, Jharkhand

The exposure of 14 instances of objections to unilateral decisions concerning electoral rolls points to an assault on our democracy. However, a

bureaucrat does not
weaponise a constitutional
body in a vacuum. There
appears to be a conspiracy
to engineer poll outcomes
from behind the scenes. If
constitutional institutions
are compromised, those
responsible must face legal
consequences to restore
trust.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

Form 26 and the statutory mandate

Although Natarajan has been granted liberty to challenge her rejection through an election petition under Section 100 of ROPA, the broader constitutional question survives. It may be time for the Supreme Court to revisit *Ponnuswami* and clarify whether constitutional courts should remain powerless even in the face of patent arbitrariness during the electoral process.

The case raises questions about the scope of the disclosure obligations imposed on candidates and constitutional remedies available when nomination papers are rejected

CM
YK

CJP leader, 41 volunteers detained by Assam Police

They were released in the evening; CJP spokesperson says the detainees were not served with any legal notice; CJP wanted to talk about fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, he says

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Assam Police on Sunday detained Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka and several others from a private residence in Guwahati. They were released later in the evening.

According to CJP spokesperson Anish Gawande, the others included 41 local volunteers and Mr. Ranka's associates, Ankit Bharadwaj and Prem Aakash.

"Six of those detained along with Ashutosh Ranka are women. They were taken to the [Dispur] police station from a private residence, where a meet-up of CJP volunteers was scheduled," Mr. Gawande told presspersons.

"The illegal detention by Assam Police has finally ended. We have asked Police to go and drop us from where we were picked up illegally in the first place," Mr. Ranka said in a post on



Rallying cry: CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka at a protest ahead of its first regional volunteers' meeting in Assam on Sunday. PTI

X after being released along with the other detainees.

The CJP leaders and volunteers were not served with any legal notice, and they were also not told which sections of the law they had been detained under, Mr. Gawande said.

"This is nothing short of jungle raj under Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who is afraid of any and all kind of dissent," Mr. Gawande said.

All the CJP wanted to talk about was fixing the pathetic condition of schools in Assam, which do not have fans, classrooms, and teachers, he said.

"We wanted to talk about the way people have been evicted from Kaziranga, their lands taken, and activists arrested. We wanted to talk about the illegal redrawing of the election (constituency) boundaries in Assam," he said.

The CJP alleged that there had been a pattern in Assam "happening for too long".

"You have seen what happened with land rights activist Pranab Doley, who was arrested and then detained under the National Security Act. You have seen how the government intimidates civil society activists in Assam," Mr. Gawande said.

'Chief Minister is afraid' Earlier in the day, Mr. Ranka asked why the Chief Minister was afraid of being exposed.

"The Chief Minister is scared that if we show the schools here, the country will know the reality. He is afraid that people will know how their rights were being snatched in Kaziranga for the benefit of the corporates. But we are not afraid of him. We know that he won the Assembly election by redrawing boundaries of constituencies," Mr. Ranka said.

CPI(M) leader, AAP chief discuss EC row, ED action against ex-Keralam CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the INDIA bloc meeting scheduled for September 30 to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby met Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal in Delhi on Sunday.

The leaders discussed the recent report on Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar allegedly ignoring objections raised by the two Election Commissioners on the special intensive revision exercise and the Enforcement Directorate's action against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.

The meeting comes days after Mr. Baby wrote to INDIA bloc parties and other non-NDA parties seeking a joint discussion on developments following reports of differences within the poll panel over the SIR exercise. Setting aside three-decade-old differences,



CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby at Aam Aadmi Party national convenor Arvind Kejriwal's residence in New Delhi on Sunday. PTI

Mr. Baby spoke to the chairperson of the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress, Mamata Banerjee, who agreed that the situation warranted coordinated action.

Meeting agenda

Mr. Baby said his primary purpose was to invite Mr. Kejriwal to participate in the Left campaign against the alleged misuse of Central investigation agencies. He underlined that the Enforcement Directorate, which had been used against Mr. Kejriwal and his colleague Manish Sisodia, was now being deployed

against former Keralam Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in what he described as a sustained attempt to tarnish his image. The two leaders also discussed the "authoritarian manner" in which Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar was functioning and the need for a united Opposition effort to expose his alleged wrongdoing.

The INDIA bloc meeting is expected to discuss the functioning of the Election Commission, the SIR exercise, and the Opposition's course of action, including seeking the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

Mamata camp leader faces attack twice in two days

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Beleghata MLA Kunal Ghosh was allegedly attacked on Sunday and his vehicle was damaged by unidentified miscreants.

This was the second attack on the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) leader in two days. Mr. Ghosh was attacked at Uttarpara in Hooghly district on Saturday when he was on the way to attend a meeting called by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee.

"Today I was once again the target of an attempted murder. It all happened in the city of Kolkata, in broad daylight and on a Sunday, when I was on my way to attend a programme as an MLA. They were armed; they smashed the car window and tried to drag me out, brandishing revolvers. My security personnel had to draw their weapons," Mr. Ghosh said.

The journalist-turned-politician lodged a complaint at the Narkeldanga police station.

Congress to hold self-respect meet over 'purification' ritual

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Stepping up its campaign against the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) governments at the Centre and in Uttarakhand, the Congress's SC/ST Parliamentarians Forum on Sunday announced a "Dalit-Adivasi Self-Respect Meeting" in Delhi on September 29 over the "purification ritual" conducted in Haldwani last month after a rally addressed by party president Mallikarjun Kharge.

Congress MP Mallu Ravi said the incident reflected the mindset of the Uttarakhand and Union governments. He criticised the Uttarakhand government's initial refusal to register an FIR in the matter.

"The Prime Minister, Home Minister and Uttarakhand Chief Minister have not yet condemned the incident," he said.

'Modi govt. is anti-Dalit' Congress leader Manoj Kumar alleged that the Modi government was "anti-Da-

lit" and "anti-tribal" and claimed that atrocities against Dalits and tribals had increased.

He appealed to Dalit and tribal legislators to participate in the meeting.

The meeting would discuss incidents of discrimination and violence against Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes that violate the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955, and the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989.

Over 2,000 citizens write to CJI to stay SIR, start suo motu proceedings on EC conduct

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Over 2,000 citizens across the country have signed an open letter to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant to initiate *suo motu* proceedings against the operational and administrative conduct of the Election Commission of India regarding the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise and the deployment of ECINet.

The letter seeks the im-

mediate stay and rescission of the SIR exercise across all States and Union Territories pending a thorough, independent judicial review of its legality and procedural integrity in light of the new facts that have emerged.

They have also sought an independent, court-monitored investigation into allegations of arbitrary, unauthorised changes made to voter registration software/forms. The open letter has sought a direc-

tion from the court for "appropriate penal/procedural action against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and officials for overriding statutory procedures and disregarding the constitutional mandate of the multi-member Commission".

The signatories have also sought a comprehensive security and legal audit of the ECINet software platform by an independent expert committee appointed by the top court to res-

tore decentralised control to local Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) as mandated by law and verify whether any persons other than statutory officers had access to the platform.

The letter urged the court's intervention to order the immediate reinstatement of voters whose names were deleted.

"When the institutional safeguards designed to protect the electoral roll are compromised from

within, judicial intervention becomes vital to preserve public faith in the democratic process," the letter said.

The signatories include academic Aditya Nigam, filmmaker Aditya Seth, Admiral Vishnu Bhagwat (retired), retired IAS officer Aditi Mehta, activists Amrita Johri and Anjali Bhardwaj, former DU professor Anita Rampal, retired JNU Professor Nivedita Menon, advocate Prashant Bhushan and actor Prakash Raj.

BJP slams Rahul over SIR, accuses Opposition parties of maligning institutions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday fielded its Chief Ministers and stepped up its attack on the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, the Congress, and its allies over the special intensive revision (SIR), accusing them of making unsubstantiated claims.

Alleging that Mr. Gandhi and other Opposition leaders were conspiring to malign the country's constitutional institutions, the BJP said the Election Commission of India had already issued a press note and a fact-based clarification of the "fabricated allegations".

"Despite this, the Congress and its allies, frustrated by their repeated electoral defeats, remain determined to undermine constitutional propriety in an attempt to conceal their failures. From North to South and East to West, this misinformation aimed at weakening the country's democratic framework and creating anarchy is being strongly countered across the nation," the party said in a statement.

Chief Ministers Yogi Adityanath, Devendra Fadnavis, Himanta Biswa Sarma, Bhajan Lal Sharma, Bhupendra Patel, Nayab Singh Saini, Vishnu Deo Sai, Pushkar Singh Dhami, Rekha Gupta, Samrat Choudhary, Mohan Yadav and Suvenud Adhikari hit out at the Congress.

Mr. Fadnavis accused Mr. Gandhi of seeking to discredit institutions under the guise of defending the Constitution and deliberately creating confusion and chaos by repeatedly questioning constitution-



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis dismisses vote-theft claims, saying Rahul Gandhi's 'mind has been stolen'. FILE

al bodies. "There has been no vote theft, Rahul Gandhi's mind has been stolen," he said.

Alleging that the Opposition parties had created confusion over the SIR, Mr. Adityanath sought an apology from the Congress and its allies.

Mr. Sarma described the Opposition as an "alliance of defeated people", while Mr. Yadav alleged that Mr. Gandhi was spreading falsehoods after failing to manage his party.

Ms. Gupta demanded an apology, accusing the Opposition of "creating this baseless controversy to divert attention from its failures, its betrayal of the country and the development works being undertaken".

Mr. Adhikari said the Congress supported SIR in Kerala because it won there but opposed it in West Bengal after losing the election.

He said judicial officers were dealing with names rejected due to logical discrepancies, adding that the Opposition was misleading the public.

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF TELANGANA LIMITED
E - PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
The TGTRANSCO invites bids online for the following work: 1) Spec.No. e-TGTLI-17/2026-27, Name of work: Supply, Erection, Testing and commissioning of Conversion of existing 132kV 2-Ph DC line to 3-Ph DC line (4.5km) from 220/132kV SS Malyalapalli & erection of new 132kV 3-Ph DC line of 4km to proposed 132kV Ramagundam RTSS along with connected bays at 220/132kV SS Malyalapalli and 132kV Ramagundam RTSS. 2) Spec.No.e-TGTLI-18/2026-27, Name of work: Supply of Material/Equipment including Transportation & Insurance, Delivery, Erection, Testing & Commissioning and Civil & Construction of the following works on Turnkey basis in Narayanpet District: (i)220/11kV LISS at Vutkur, Bapur(V), Vutkur(M) (ii) 220kV TMDC Line from proposed 220/11kV SS at Budpur SS to proposed 220/11kV SS at Vutkur SS (24.574KM), (iii) 220kV TMDC Line from proposed 220/11kV Jayammacheruvu SS to proposed 220/11kV LISS at Vutkur (13.073KM) under Makthal- Narayanpet- Kodangal Lift Irrigation Scheme-(Package-2) Tender Availability on website from: 28.09.2026. Note: Further details can be seen in website: <http://tender.telanganagov.in> FAX NO. 040-23323565, Phone No.040-23396000 Extn.3552/3424/3644/3415/3687/3627. DIPR R.O. No. 582-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/LIS

TOURISM CORPORATION OF GUJARAT LIMITED (TCGL)
(A Government of Gujarat undertaking)
Nigam Bhavan Sector 16, Block C First Floor, Nr. GH 4½ Bus Stand, Gandhinagar – 382 016. Website: <https://www.gujarattourism.com>
TENDER NOTICE
Bids are invited from reputed and experienced Agencies for providing service towards "Third-Party Inspection Agencies for Monitoring and Inspection of Cleaning and Sanitation Services across various tourist locations in Gujarat". The project requirements, technical specifications, eligibility criteria, selection process, etc. are included in the Tender documents, which shall be available for download from the websites: <https://tender.nprocure.com/> and <https://www.gujarattourism.com> from 28/09/2026 onwards. The last date for submission of the Technical Bid and Financial Bid (online only) is 19/10/2026 up to 6:00 pm. and Technical Bid (physical only) is 22/10/2026 up to 3:00 pm. Managing Director

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, MEGA LIFT, BHUBANESWAR.
Plot No. A 8/2, Bhoinagar, Bhubaneswar, Odisha, PIN-751022, E-Mail : cemlpwr.od@gmail.com
Government of Odisha - "e" Procurement Notice
(Bid Identification No. 15ML/2026-27)
The Chief Engineer, Megalift on behalf of the Governor of Odisha invites online tender through "E" procurement for the works as mentioned in the Annexure to this bid notice.
ANNEXURE TO BID NOTICE

Name of the work	Appointment of Third Party Inspection Agency (TPIA) for Implementation of Mega Lift projects in Cluster No. XXXI & XXXVI.
Cost of Tender Paper	Rs.10,000/-
EMD/Bid Security	Rs.1,29,000/-
Mode of payment of tender paper Cost & EMD	Online
Period of Completion	36(Thirty-Six) Calendar months
Availability of Bid document for sale and receipt through on-line	From dt.29.09.2026, 10.00 A.M. to dt.21.10.2026, up to 5.00 P.M
Last date / time of receipt of bid in the portal	21.10.2026 (5.00 PM)
Date of Pre-bid Conference	12.10.2026, 11.00 AM
Date of opening of Techno-Commercial bid through online	On dt. 22.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M in the Office of the Chief Engineer, Megalift.
Class of Contractor	The bidder should be registered under the Companies Act, 1956/2013
Digital Signature Certificate of Bidder	The Bidder must possess compatible digital signature certificate (DSC).
The detail tender call notice can also be seen in the DOWR web site - https://dowr.odisha.gov.in	
Name & Address of the OIT	Chief Engineer, Megalift, Plot No. A-8/2, Bhoi Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751022, Ph.No-0674-2567252, Email ID : cemlpwr.od@gmail.com
Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement market place, https://tendersodisha.gov.in	
Chief Engineer, Megalift, Bhubaneswar. OIPR-32001/32478/1/26-27/0014	
32001/919/2627	

India's women continue to rule Asian cricket, but another gold in Aichi-Nagoya raises a bigger question: where is the competition that can challenge their dominance?

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INBRIEF



3-storey building collapses in Haryana, 4 dead, 12 injured

Four people died while more than ten were injured when a three-storeyed building under construction collapsed at Dhulkot village near Ambala City in Haryana on Sunday, officials said. The incident unfolded in the late afternoon when the concrete slab (lintel) for the roof was being cast on the first floor, prompting locals to initiate rescue efforts before informing the police and emergency services. One of the injured workers claimed that some labourers were working on the ground floor, while others were engaged in the casting work above. Ambala Civil Surgeon Renu Beri told reporters that 12 injured labourers were brought to the hospital, of whom five are still admitted, two were discharged on request, while the others were discharged after first aid. PTI

IndiGo A321 plane involved in another tail strike

An IndiGo Airbus A321 was involved in yet another tail strike at Bengaluru airport on Sunday, marking at least the ninth known such incident involving the airline's A321 fleet. In a statement, IndiGo said an "abnormal runway contact" occurred during "gusty wind conditions" in Bengaluru. The aircraft was operating a flight from Guwahati. It aborted its initial landing attempt at Bengaluru airport before making a final landing at 12.15 p.m., industry sources said. A tail strike occurs when the rear section of an aircraft comes into contact with the runway during landing, take-off, or a go-around.

Census 2027 is a 'national responsibility', says Modi

Data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded during the nationwide exercise, PM says in *Mann Ki Baat*; he also highlights Indian armed forces' decisive response to terror attacks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

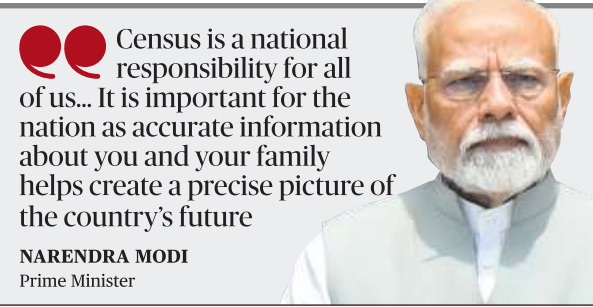
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday described Census 2027 as a national responsibility requiring public participation. With over 32 crore families recorded and 2.6 crore people having self-enumerated digitally, he said accurate information about people and their families would help create a precise picture of the country's future.

During his *Mann Ki Baat* address, Mr. Modi said: "The facility to self-register your Census details is very convenient. You can register information about yourself and your family from your mobile itself."

"The first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all States and Union Territories; data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded," he said.

Over 2.6 crore people had already entered their details on the Census portal through mobile phones without uploading any documents, he added.

During his address, Mr. Modi paid tributes to the victims of the September



2008 Delhi serial blasts, the 26/11 Mumbai attack and the 9/11 U.S. terrorist attacks.

Recalling India's surgical strike on September 28-29, 2016, he said the Indian Army demonstrated a decisive response by crossing the Line of Control to target terrorist hideouts in Pakistan. He highlighted the Balakot air strike and Operation Sindoor as instances of India's zero-tolerance counter-terrorism approach.

On the "Somnath Swabhimani Parv", he said Mahmud of Ghazni demolished the Somnath Temple for the first time in 1026 and the same year, the Sun Temple in Gujarat's Modherna was also attacked and destroyed. He said despite invasions and destruction of temples, the people and rulers of that period did

not lose their resolve and rebuilt them.

Praise for expert

Mr. Modi hailed the contribution of A. Selvaraju, associated with the Department of Tamil Studies at a college in Manapparai in Tamil Nadu's Tiruchirappalli.

He said Mr. Selvaraju discovered several sculptures and ancient temples, helping people understand and connect with the past.

Referring to the recently concluded Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations, Mr. Modi noted that India's spiritual and cultural heritage transcended national boundaries, citing Thailand resident

Panthoun Thirkhanon's decades-long study and promotion of Ganesha traditions in that country.

With Mahatma Gandhi's

birth anniversary approaching on October 2, he said cleanliness was one of Gandhiji's guiding principles.

Green drive

On environment conservation, he noted the achievements made in the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary, Assam, where land was cleared of encroachment for the once-displaced elephants to return to their natural habitat.

In West Bengal's Sundarbans, some women from Jharkhali – most of whom lost their husbands to tiger attacks – were creating mangrove forests, which were not only serving as a natural protective shield for villages but also creating income opportunities, Mr. Modi said.

Stating that the month of September is dedicated to the fight against malnutrition, he noted that Chhattisgarh was promoting *moringa* through "*Har Ghar Munga*"; Gujarat was encouraging nutritious millet dishes through "*Vangi Spardha*"; Maharashtra was conducting nutrition-awareness campaigns; and Mizoram was supporting "*Poshan Vatikas*".

PM pays tribute to Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday paid tribute to former Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) international working president Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary, describing him as an "organisational genius" and recalling his "pivotal role" in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

In an op-ed article, Mr. Modi recalled his many interactions with Singhal, who was born on September 27, 1926, and passed away on November 17, 2015. "I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection," Mr. Modi wrote.

"One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young *Karyakarta* going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him," he added. "Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me." Mr. Modi wrote about Singhal both as a person as well as an administrator.

He recalled how he saw Singhal work hard on various projects that involved "long and often difficult travels".

"His mind was constant-

He hailed the former VHP international working president's 'pivotal role' in Ram Janmabhoomi movement

ly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society," Mr. Modi recalled. "Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding *Karyakartas* to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable."

Mr. Modi highlighted Singhal's role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. "Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991," he asked. "Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible." "He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya," Mr. Modi wrote.

Tribal students to embark on 180-km march to Mumbai

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
NASHIK

Hundreds of tribal students in Maharashtra will embark on a nearly 180-km march from Nashik to Mumbai on Monday, pressing the government to address their demands for better facilities, safety, and accountability in government-run residential schools.

Spearheaded by the Sakal Adivasi Vidyarthi Andolan Kruti Samiti, the long march comes 40 days after a sit-in at the Idgah Maidan in Nashik. The protest continues, with a small slate declaring the day of protest hanging from the ceiling of a temporary pandal. Posters of Birsu Munda, Bhagat Singh and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar surround the protesters as they take turns to sit on strike.

Among the demands of the protesters are the resig-



Tribal students at the sit-in at Nashik's Idgah Maidan. The protest has been going on for the past 40 days. VINAYA DESHPANDE PANDIT

nation of Maharashtra Tribal Development Minister Ashok Uike, the transfer of the Tribal Development Department's Secretary and Commissioner, basic facilities in tribal schools and hostels, an independent inquiry into tribal students' deaths at residential schools, and financial assistance for victims.

"Last month, the government held discussions with protesters from Pune and Nagpur. Tribals from

Nashik did not join them. The government gave them false promises. We are in touch with tribals from Nashik, Khandesh, North Maharashtra, Marathwada, and Vidarbha. We expect around 1,500 students to join us on the first day of the protest march," tribal leader Rahul Pawra told *The Hindu*. Protesters also raised concerns over the food provided by central kitchens to tribal schools.

Student's death can't be seen in isolation: IIT-Bombay alumni

Vinaya Vilas Deshpande
MUMBAI

The death by suicide of Sahil Wakode cannot be viewed in isolation, alumni of Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay (IITB) said on Sunday. The incident pointed to a deeper problem within the academic environment, they said. In a letter written to the Director of the institute, a group of alumni have also expressed concerns over the increasingly "militarised campus" during exams. Calling for immediate, comprehensive reforms, they sought a survey of the students' mental health and a humane approach to deal with instances of misconduct.

The alumni expressed deep anguish about a series of deaths by suicide at the institute. The 10 de-

mands put forth by them include a call for an immediate and impartial investigation into specific allegations of caste-based harassment and improved mental health support, including mandatory faculty sensitisation.

"We sincerely hope that the institute will take concrete steps to ensure that the academic climate at IITB is egalitarian, humane and conducive to intellectual growth. This requires addressing the caste, class and gender-based inequalities... that are deeply embedded in our society and can manifest within academic institutions," the letter, accessed by *The Hindu*, stated.

[Those in distress may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline: 011-40769002.]

Boeing finds glitch in guidance system of some 737-MAX planes

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Boeing has detected a software issue in some of its B737-MAX planes that could result in disengagement of the automated flight guidance system after a missed landing approach, and the aircraft maker is working on a permanent solution, according to sources.

In India, there are 96 Boeing 737-MAX planes operated by Air India Express (53) and Akasa Air (43).

"Last month, we informed all 737 operators about a software issue where pilots may experience a reduction in automation during a landing scenario. We shared information with operators that reinforced existing pilot procedures for safely handling such cases," the spokesperson said in a statement.



Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system as a precautionary measure to address the issue. FILE PHOTO

Boeing has issued an advisory to operators to reset the system following a missed approach as a precautionary measure to address the issue, sources said.

"We are closely coordinating with Boeing and can confirm that there is no impact to the safety of Akasa Air operations. Our aircraft continue to operate safely in accordance with established procedures and applicable regulatory requirements," an airline

spokesperson said in a statement.

However, the carrier did not specifically mention whether any of its Boeing 737-MAX planes had been impacted due to the issue. There was no response from Air India Express.

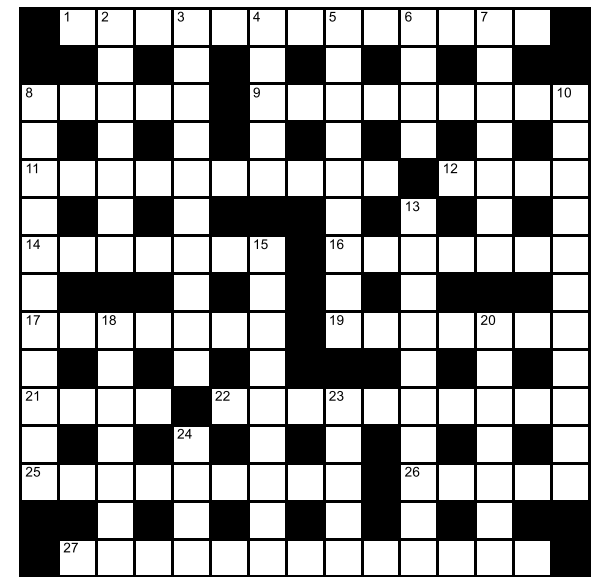
There was no immediate response from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on whether it was probing the issue and whether any advisory was issued to airlines.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14909

(set by Dr. X)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 16 Asserting briefly about making a bloomer (7)
- 17 Deceiver cheers up after ensnaring maiden (7)
- 19 Small tin can made of tin (7)
- 21 Lover starts to cuddle at first (4)
- 22 Liaison at rave after consuming cocaine - becoming rebellious (10)
- 25 Cause a commotion in bar, catching date embracing hot lady (5,4)
- 26 Lyric poet turned very tense, entertaining princess (5)
- 27 Art of artfully reshaping with latest in 3D CGI (7,6)
- Down
- 2 Runner's not at all well, close to collapse (7)
- 3 Love smart American couple welcoming members at launch individually (3,2,1,4)
- 4 Content of natural ginseng gum (5)
- 5 Desires remuneration after end of therapy (9)
- 6 Bishop, one wearing outsize sashes (4)
- 7 Model consuming ecstasy with posh fellow turned miserable (7)
- 8 Specialist beginning to chat about treatment of neurosis (11)
- 10 Knight in position trapping one's rook with clean moves (3,8)
- 13 Goad union's ridiculous dinosaurs (10)
- 15 Peaceful, having good time on island's national park (9)
- 18 Woman drinking wine, becoming more reckless (7)
- 20 Nudging to control one talking loudly (7)
- 23 Relaxed in food shop in retreat, cuddling date (5)
- 24 Look at bottom of pump for leak (4)

- Across
- 1 Where one sees the letter E explicitly? (2,2,4,5)
- 8 Advance to save boy in valley (5)
- 9 Delighted with production of oil by American plant (9)
- 11 Teen in inn excited about boy finally giving number (6-4)
- 12 Starts to appreciate fine African rhino from a distance (4)
- 14 Rose edited series about Greek mythological character (7)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Rama's justification

Dharma is sukshma, its subtle meanings difficult to grasp. We should follow what our Acharyas advise us to follow, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. Only those who practise dharma must talk about it. Rama was qualified to talk about dharma, because He was a practitioner of dharma. Vaali questions the propriety of Rama's action of shooting an arrow at him (Vaali) from behind, and wonders if His act is dharmic. Rama explains what dharma is to Vaali. Vaali's foremost sin is misbehaviour towards Sugreeva's wife. Vaali is the elder brother of Sugreeva and is therefore like a father to him. He should have treated Sugreeva as he would his son. Would it be right for a man to make his son's wife his own? Vaali, by his conduct towards Sugreeva's wife, had committed a very grave sin. Just as one must not have lustful thoughts about one's daughter or sister, likewise one must not have such thoughts about one's brother's wife.

Having broken such a fundamental rule, how could Vaali talk about dharma and hope for clemency? Dharma sastras say that a king who metes out proper punishment for a crime or a sin will enter heaven. If a thief or a sinner is punished by his king, he escapes hell. But a king who fails to punish a wrongdoer will definitely go to hell, according to the dharma sastras. As for killing Vaali from behind, do hunters have to face animals before killing them, asks Rama. Vaali has been claiming that what he did was right according to vanara dharma. If he took refuge behind the argument that he was an animal, then using the same argument, Rama could say He was justified in hitting Vaali from behind.

*Fine print:
Barely read
and rarely
understood*

Managing inflation risk

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Both working executives and retirees are exposed to inflation risk, but retirees are affected more when price levels increase. In this article, we discuss inflation risk in relation to retirees and explore how they can manage this risk.

Hedging issue

Inflation risk is the likelihood that inflation is greater than expected. You will factor in inflation for determining your terminal wealth for a goal. If you are saving to fund your child's college education, you will factor in education inflation to arrive at the amount you will need when your child enters college. Similarly, when you determine the amount you need at retirement, you must estimate the general inflation during your post-retirement years.

The risk you are exposed to is the likelihood that actual inflation will be greater than the expected inflation you factored into your retirement portfolio calculation.

Note that we are referring to general inflation that will affect your living expenses, not the health-care inflation.

The latter is typically more than double that of general inflation and can increase even when general inflation is in line with expectation.

If you are nearing retirement and are concerned about inflation risk, how should you manage the risk?

A hedge typically works when the investment product value rises in line with the increase in price level. Actual inflation can be greater than expected inflation because of rising commodity prices, especially crude oil.

So, you can buy investment products that take exposure to such commodities to hedge inflation risk. But products for the mass-affluent to hedge inflation risk are unavailable in India. Note that gold and equity investments may not be a good hedge against inflation.

Conclusion

Commodities futures typically offer a good hedge against inflation but have high downside risk and may be unsuitable for mass-affluent retirees. An alternative is rental property. Rental income may not be a hedge against inflation, but rentals can continually increase.

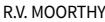
It is optimal to buy a new property just before retirement to earn market rentals. Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are an affordable alternative for those who do not want to invest lump-sum amount from their retirement corpus into rental properties. REITs are like mutual funds that invest in commercial properties to earn lease rentals.

As per SEBI regulation, REITs are required to distribute 90% of their net distributable income (lease rentals minus operating expenses) to their investors every year.

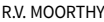
This provides for stable cash flows that could increase with inflation.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

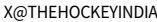
Ancy vows to come back strong after missing out on top spot



Sivasangari was incredible, I couldn't do much, says Anahat



Indian women's hockey team to play Korea in the semifinals



Kohli second after Tendulkar to score 15,000 ODI runs



Ancy misses gold by a whisker; Sarvesh brings home silver

Anahat, Abhay come up short

Kohli, Gill ace the chase after Kuldeep's heroics





Firm favourites: The Men in Blue are widely tipped to retain their gold from Hangzhou. x@BCCI

Skipper Shreyas wary of challenging surface as India meets Afghanistan

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The rains in Nagoya continued for the second day and threaten to affect India's quarterfinal against Afghanistan on Monday as the men's cricket team got a feel of the ground conditions with its only training session on Sunday.

The Korogi Sports Park that also hosted the women's competition is a modified baseball field and the hybrid pitch and outfield got a positive feedback from Harmanpreet Kaur & Co. The men, coming after a one-off, five-over match against Japan in Sano, have had little time to acclimatise to Nagoya while Afghanistan has already played two matches.

The continued rain also marred the team's attempts to have a full intensity training. Captain Shreyas Iyer, however, refused to dwell on the conditions or the facilities. "Yes, it's raining but we cannot give that as a reason because we are a bunch of professionals. Such hurdles will keep coming and mentally we have to be prepared, irrespective of whatever the situation is going to be. We got a decent warm-up and a little knocking. Tomorrow, we will try to adapt as soon as possible to the wickets and see how the

weather is. The important thing is to come and play the match," Shreyas said on the eve of the match.

Afghanistan lost a three-match T20I series 0-3 in New Delhi recently but the team here is very different and inexperienced. In fact, with an almost full-strength team, India is firm favourite to retain its gold medal but Shreyas insisted on being cautious. "Not only Afghanistan, Japan gave us a very good competition. The wicket here cannot be set in a particular standard. But it is very important to adapt. It will be challenging for every team," he said.

"Today when we woke up, we thought we would be getting a little bit of practice. We knew we would be playing on turf but as soon as we arrived, the rain started again. We were able to maximise a bit in terms of our warm-up and the bowlers did some strides in the background in the outfield and sent down a couple of overs," he pointed out.

With the Games entering the business end of competition, Shreyas also hoped to catch action from other sports. "Like today, we know that an 18-year-old prodigy (Anahat Singh) is playing a squash game, so we wanted to see that. But due to practice, we couldn't go. Our support is for every individual who is representing the country," he added.

ASIAD ROUND-UP



Ankush and Parveen after their quarterfinal wins. x@MEDIA_SAI

Three Indian boxers assured of medals

NISHIO: Indian boxers Parveen Hooda, Ankush Panghal and Narender Berwal assured the country of three medals with dominant quarterfinal wins at the Asian Games here on Sunday, while Sachin Siwach's campaign ended in the last eight stage. Parveen defeated World championships silver medallist Navbakhor Khamidova of Uzbekistan 5-0 to move into the women's 65kg semifinals. Narender (+90kg) added another medal to his bronze from the previous edition after forcing the referee to stop his quarterfinal against Thailand's Adthapong Saengtpe in less than two minutes. Ankush notched up a 5-0 unanimous decision over Tajikistan's Nekruz Salimov in the men's 80kg quarterfinal. **The results (quarterfinals): Women: 65kg:** Parveen Hooda bt Navbakhor Khamidova (Uzb) 5-0. **Men: +90kg:** Narender Berwal bt Adthapong Saengtpe (Tha) RSC;

80kg: Ankush Panghal bt Nekruz Salimov (Tjk) 5-0. **60kg:** Shunsuke Kitamoto (Jpn) bt Sachin Siwach 5-0.

Sindhu, Unnati bow out as India draws a blank
NAGOYA: P.V. Sindhu and Unnati Hooda went down in the women's singles quarterfinals on Sunday as Indian shuttlers failed to win a medal in the individual competition of the Asian Games. Sindhu, forced to play her third match in less than 24 hours, lost to Chen Yu Fei of China 21-11, 18-21, 10-21. Unnati went down 16-21, 21-14, 17-21 to three-time World champion Akane Yamaguchi of Japan. Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand suffered an 18-21, 9-21 defeat to the Malaysian World No. 5 pairing of Pearly Tan and Thinaah Muralitharan in the doubles quarterfinals. The mixed doubles duo of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto lost 14-21, 21-18, 18-21 to the Chinese World No. 1 combination of Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dongping in a last-eight clash.

India claims silver in open event; women bag the bronze medal

Arjun scores over Leko to help the team secure a draw against Hungary; Humpy stars in the draw against Georgia to ensure the side finishes on the podium; the country wins the Gaprindashvili Trophy and board medals; Uzbekistan and China emerge champions

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

The men won the silver, and the women the bronze. India, the defending champion in both the open and women's sections, could not repeat the stunning twin success of 2024, but at least finished with medals at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand.

In the open section, host Uzbekistan emerged the champion, while China came up with a dominant show to win the women's title despite not fielding some of its best players.

On the final day, the Indian men drew with Hungary 2-2, while the women shared the honours with Georgia (2-2).

The Indian men finished with 18 points, two less than the host, which defeated Ukraine 2.5-1.5. Germany, which surprised many, won the bronze after its 2.5-1.5 win over the Nether-



Impressive show: The Indian teams finished among the medals while Praggnanandhaa, Gukesh, Humpy, Divya and Savitha Shri, second right, came up with consistent displays and also took home individual prizes. FIDE



lands. Arjun Erigaisi's win over Peter Leko on the second board proved crucial, as D. Gukesh was beaten by Gleb Dudin. R. Praggnanandhaa and Nihal Sarin drew their games.

Significant win

For the Indian women, Koneru Humpy scored a significant win on the top board against Nana Dzagnidze. Though Divya Deshmukh lost on the second board, to Bela Khotenashvili, Vantika Agrawal and

the magnificent B. Savitha Shri both drew their games to ensure India would end up on the podium, after all.

Slew of board medals

India also retained the Gaprindashvili Trophy, given to the team with the best overall score.

India is the only country to win a medal in both open and women's sections.

India also won a slew of board medals. Savitha struck gold on the reserve

board in the women's section while Divya won the silver on the second board.

Humpy and Vantika the bronze on the top and fourth boards respectively. In the open section, Gukesh won the silver on the fourth board, while Praggnanandhaa claimed the bronze on the top board.

Important results (final round): Open:

India drew with Hungary 2-2 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Richard Rapport; Arjun Erigaisi bt Peter Leko; Nihal Sarin drew with

Benjamin Gledura; D. Gukesh lost to Gleb Dudin).

Uzbekistan bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; Germany bt Netherlands 2.5-1.5; USA bt Turkey 3-1; Serbia bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt Croatia 3-1; China bt Uzbekistan (2) 3-1; France bt Denmark 3.5-0.5; England bt Italy 2.5-1.5; Spain bt Georgia 3-1.

The standings: 1. Uzbekistan 20; 2-3. India and Germany 18; 4-7. USA, Azerbaijan, Armenia and Hungary 17; 8-10. China, France and Spain 16.

Women: India drew with Georgia 2-2 (Koneru Humpy bt Nana Dzagnidze; Divya

Deshmukh lost to Bela Khotenashvili; Vantika Agrawal drew with Lela Javakhishvili; B. Savitha Shri drew with Meri Arabidze).

Armenia bt Uzbekistan 3-1; China bt Vietnam 3-1; Kazakhstan drew with Poland 2-2; USA bt Romania 3-1; Mongolia bt Greece 2.5-1.5; France drew with Slovenia 2-2; Bulgaria drew with Latvia 2-2; Indonesia drew with Spain 2-2; Turkey bt Sri Lanka 3-1.

The standings: 1. China 20; 2. Kazakhstan 18; 3-7. India, USA, Poland, Armenia and Mongolia 17; 8-10. Georgia, Vietnam and Slovenia 16.

Ishaan notches up season's maiden victory in MRF Formula 2000 class

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Bengaluru's Ishaan Madesh registered his first win of the season in the MRF Formula 2000 class in the second round of the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 4W-2026 which concluded here on Sunday.

Ishaan, who finished second and third in the first two races of the weekend, came into his own in the third to end Pune's Saishiva Sankaran's streak of five consecutive victories across two rounds.

The results (Final, all 8 laps unless mentioned): MRF F2000 (Race-2, 10 laps): 1. Saishiva Sankaran (16:06.547secs); 2. Ishaan Madesh (16:13.734); 3.



Surging ahead: Ishaan delivered in the third race.

Swarnav Das (16:23.293). **Race-3:** 1. Ishaan (12:54.597); 2. Saishiva (13:03.529); 3. Krishay Gutte (13:06.041). **MRF F1600 (Race-2, 10 laps):** 1. S. Gyan (17:35.235); 2. Bhuvan Bonu (17:35.549); 3. Shivansh Bejoy (17:39.506). **Race-3:** 1. Bhuvan (13:57.878); 2. Gyan (14:10.759); 3. Shivansh (14:17.501). **Formula LGB 1300 (Race-2, 10 laps):** 1. Aadam (11:51.860); 2. Ishaan Madesh (18:56.086); 2. Liron

Jaden Samuels (DTS) (18:57.614); 3. Vinith Kumar (DTS) (18:58.572). **Race-3 (6 laps):** 1. Viswas (11:37.984); 2. Liron (11:38.576); 3. Dhruv Goswami (Meco Racing) (11:40.965). **Junior (Race-2, 10 laps):** 1. Shatveer Shetty (Meco Racing) (19:21.666); 2. Aadam Junaid (Momentum Motorsports) (19:36.677); 3. Dhrihan Dagha (Meco) (19:39.313). **Race-3 (6 laps):** 1. Aadam (11:51.860); 2. Kaveen Diyyan Rajapksa

We have signed players who have a point to prove: Miranda

ISL

S. Shrivathsan
CHENNAI

Chennaiyin FC head coach Clifford Miranda knows full well that he will be under the spotlight in the upcoming Indian Super League season.

He has been backed by the management with plenty of incomings despite the club's dismal show in the last edition, where CFC finished a lowly 13th among 14 teams. The new-look squad, Miranda believes, will be able to challenge the usual heavyweights. "We had a lot of problems last season, but we tried to play well. The idea was to sign younger players to reduce the average age," he told *The Hindu*.

"We consciously took the decision to recruit promising young players, which will benefit the club in the long term. I want the team to play a certain way with and without the ball. It is going to require players



Miranda.

who are eager to prove a point. We have players who are on that border... those who are yet to fully establish themselves [at this level]."

For Miranda, showing relentless energy throughout a game is non-negotiable. "Football is won and lost in phases. With the quality that we have, I want us to fight and dominate the ball. At the same time, I want to see us run. It is one of the factors that led to us finishing where we did last season. You cannot win football matches if you do not run." The 'Marina Arena' awaits. Will Miranda's men turn the tide and make waves?

Tharun moves into the final

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

S. Tharun of Raman Table Tennis High Performance Centre defeated M.R. Balamurugan (Chennai) 12-10, 11-9, 11-9, 10-12, 11-4 in the men's semifinals of the TNTTA sixth State-ranking table tennis tournament.

Other results (semifinals):

Men: P.B. Abhinandh (Chennai Achievers) bt Anandhraj (SRSA) 9-11, 11-8, 11-8, 11-8, 11-8.

U-19 boys: Abhinandh bt S. Mehan (Achievers) 11-2, 12-10, 11-5; K. Umesh (RTTHPC) bt Nikhil Menon 11-7, 11-7, 8-11, 11-9.

U-17: M. Mohammed (SK Academy) bt A. Achinth (ITTC) 11-6, 2-11, 11-6, 9-11, 11-7; Akshay Bhushan bt Vishruth Ramakrishnan (MST) 11-5, 11-4, 11-6.

Women: M. Ananya (Achievers) bt Nithyashree Mani (SBI) 8-11, 11-8, 11-7, 9-11, 6-11, 11-7, 14-12; Yashini (SK) bt Nalene Amrutha (MVM) 11-5, 9-11, 9-11, 11-5, 8-11, 11-5, 11-8.

U-19 girls: B.R. Nandhini (MVM) bt R. Mercy (ACE) 11-6, 11-1, 11-8; Ananya bt B. Varnica (SSA-ERD) 5-11, 13-11, 11-5, 10-12, 11-3.

U-17: Varnica bt R. Mercy (ACE) 11-5, 5-11, 11-9, 9-11, 12-10; Ananya bt Samyra Rajesh (ITTC) 11-4, 11-7, 11-8.

Love All primed to complete hat-trick

RACING

HYDERABAD: The four-year-old filly Love All, who won in her last two starts, should score a hat-trick in the Dr. Harish Chandra Memorial Trophy, the main event of Monday's (Sept. 28) races.

1. NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200m), Terms, Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 1.15 p.m.: 1. Ashwa Vivegam (4) Gaurav 56, 2. Mantle Plume (2) B.R. Kumar 56, 3. Svalpaviryasakti (3) Md. Ismail 56, 4. Bayone (9) D.S. Deora 54.5, 5. First Kiss (10) Afroz K 54.5, 6. Lion's Pride (6) R.N. Darshan 54.5, 7. Menlo Park (8) Shivam 54.5, 8. Night Whisper (5) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 9. Veera's Lakshmi (7) Ajay K 54.5 and 10. Vespucci (1) Mohit 54.5.

1. MANTLE PLUME, 2. FIRST KISS, 3. ASHWA VIVEGAM

2. TWIN CITIES PLATE (1,800m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 46 (Cat. III), 1.45: 1. Hoping Star (7) Arjun 60, 2. Hoping High (1) Mohit 58.5, 3. Silver Arrow (5) Kuldeep Sr. 58, 4. Evansville (3) Akshay K 54, 5. Nkalanzinzi (6) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 6. Aloy (2) Sohan 53, 7. AAKARSHAKA (8) Md. Ismail 52.5 and 8. American Gangster (4) M.S. Deora 51.5.

1. EVANSVILLE, 2. HOPING HIGH, 3. HOPING STAR

3. NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200m), Terms, Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 2.15: 1. Daryoosh (1) Md. Ekram 56, 2. Sporting Touch (10) M.S. Deora 56, 3. Wildstar (6) Mukesh K 56, 4. Calista Babe (4) B. Nikhil 54.5, 5. Goddess Of Light (7) Akshay K. 54.5, 6. Mazagan (3) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 7. Miss Lovely Angel (8) Ashad Asbar 54.5, 8. My Day (2) Gaurav 54.5, 9. N R Royal Power (5) Afroz K 54.5 and 10. Sara (9) Mohit 54.5.

1. WILDSTAR, 2. GODDESS OF LIGHT, 3. MAZAGAN

y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 2.50: 1. Racing Ruler (4) Kuldeep Sr. 60, 2. Authoritarian (6) M.S. Deora 58, 3. White Pearl (1) Md. Ekram 57, 4. Special Star (3) P. Sai K 54, 5. Sangreal (5) Swarup 52.5 and 6. Love All (2) Akshay K 50.5.

1. LOVE ALL, 2. AUTHORITARIAN

5. MAJOR MIR MUJTABA HUSSAIN MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 3.25: 1. Detective (3) M.S. Deora 62, 2. Romantic Grey (10) Ashad Asbar 62, 3. Clefairy (6) Akshay K 60.5, 4. Shadow Fax (9) Shivam 60.5, 5. Torchbearer (4) Kuldeep Jr. 60.5, 6. Clara (4) Kuldeep Sr. 58, 7. Rival (5) Ajay K 57, 8. Shoolin (1) D.S. Deora 56.5, 9. Bold Beauty (11) Md. Ismail 56, 10. Crimson Flame (7) Surya Prakash 54.5, 11. Federer (2) Arjun 54.5, 12. Petra Act (8) Mukesh K 53.5, 13. Colt Pistol (12) Sonu K 53 and 14. Coming Home (13) B. Nikhil 51.

1. CLEFAIRY, 2. RIVAL, 3. CLARA

6. NOBLE QUEST PLATE (1,200m) (Terms), 3-y-o and upward, (Cat. II) (no whips), 4.00: 1. Hurricane Bay (7) Md. Ekram 60, 2. Walking Thunder (2) Kuldeep Sr. 60, 3. N R I High Power (1) Akshay K 58.5, 4. Reigning Beauty (6) Md. Ismail 58.5, 5. Bashir (3) Abhay Singh 58, 6. Knight Regent (9) Afroz K 58, 7. D Minchu (8) Ashad Asbar 56.5, 8. Glorious Power (4) Bhawani S 56.5 and 9. Noble Heart (5) Shivam 55.

1. N R I HIGH POWER, 2. KNIGHT REGENT, 3. GLORIOUS POWER

7. NAGARKURNOOL PLATE (1,400m) Maiden, 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 4.35: 1. La Quinta (5) Akshay K 60, 2. Dream To Fly (7) G. Nareesh 58.5, 3. Konaseema (9) Md. Ekram 56.5, 4. Lion's Gate (3) Arjun 55, 5. Beech Wood (4) Gaurav 54.5, 6. Parsiri (2) Sohan 54.5, 7. Divine Faith (8) B.R. Kumar 54, 8. Meadow (4) Arjun 53, 9. Sugriva (6) Mohit 53 and 10. Vedanta (10) Kuldeep Jr. 52.

TNCA League Sub-Committee, besides having been a Tamil Nadu age-group selector.

Timur Turlov is second-youngest president of FIDE

SAMARKAND: Timur Turlov was elected FIDE president on Saturday. At 38, Turlov, the president of Kazakhstan Federation, is the second-youngest elected president of FIDE after Kirsan Ilyumzhinov who took office in 1995 aged 33.

Indian women to play two friendlies against Russia next month

KOLKATA: The Indian women's national team will face Russia in two international friendlies at Kishore Bharati Krirangan in Kolkata on October 8 and 11 during the FIFA women's international match window.

Indian women to play two friendlies against Russia next month

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA pre-round-robin under-14 tournament, City-I vs. City-II (St. Bede's-A); City-IV vs. City-V (St. Bede's-B), 9 a.m.

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
Cricket: Asian Games (Men), Afghanistan vs India, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m. & 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday).

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

There was a moment in the second half of the Asian Games kabaddi gold-medal match against Iran when Aslam Inamdar made a daring raid deep into the opposition half.

His teammate Pawan Sehrawat groaned inwardly as he did so. India's lead was narrow. Iran was still in the contest. It was a risk that could have gone badly wrong. "It was a bad decision," Pawan would say later. But Inamdar made the dash count, securing two touches and emerging unscathed. The points brought India closer to victory. "It was a wrong move, but *ant bhala toh sab bhala* (if the end is good, it's all worth it)," Inamdar said after the match.

He grinned when he recalled the sequence later. It had been a tough decision to make. Wasn't he worried when he made that move? What would have happened if it had gone wrong? "*Bhai*, I've gone through things you wouldn't even imagine. This is nothing," he said.

That, in many ways, is the story of Aslam Inamdar.

There was a time when, as a 14-year-old, he travelled across Maharashtra in search of kabaddi tournaments without even having enough money for a train ticket. He slept under train seats, survived on stale vada pav or whatever food was available at tournaments. He sometimes stuffed leftover food which often spilled into his bag. "If there was work to be done, I did it. I've cleaned toilets. I've sold juice and made tea. I've worked in fields. If there was a kabaddi tournament to play, I found a way to get there."

In Nagoya on Saturday, Inamdar stood on the mat as India beat Iran to win the men's kabaddi gold. It is his second Asian Games gold medal. The distance between those two versions of Inamdar is difficult even for him to comprehend.

"It still feels like a dream to me," he said. "I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals."

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children.

His father passed away when he was young, leaving his mother to raise the family. She worked in other homes, doing household chores and washing utensils, to keep the family going. Later, his elder brother Waseem joined the police force and took responsibility, including helping arrange the marriages of their two sisters.

Money was scarce. Inamdar remembers growing up in a house without proper flooring or roof. There were times when even food was difficult to come by.

So, he learnt early that work meant survival. At 11 or 12, he collected



discarded bottles and sold them to scrap dealers to buy food. Later, he worked at tea stalls and juice bars, washed utensils, cleaned washrooms and worked in farm fields. He admits he stole sometimes. "It was just to fill my stomach. I faced many hard situations without letting them break me," he said.

Through all of it, there was one constant: kabaddi. Waseem was a well-known player across several districts while senior player Rahul Bhor also inspired him. Inamdar wanted to establish his own identity. "No matter how long I worked during the day or night, I always went to the ground to train," the raider said.

Kabaddi was a sport he could afford. It required little equipment, and the village ground was enough. For a boy with very little money, it offered something priceless: a chance. By the time he was 14 or 15, Inamdar was travelling alone to tournaments to compete in the 50kg and 55kg categories. He earned between ₹200

From cleaning rest rooms to winning two Asian Games golds – the rise of Aslam Inamdar

The star raider has cleared many hurdles and come a long way since taking to kabaddi when he was about 14; irrespective of the hardships, the sport has been a constant



and ₹500 a match. The money was little, but it mattered. It bought him meals when he might otherwise have gone hungry. More importantly, it kept him moving from one tournament to the next. The path was neither smooth nor uninterrupted. In 2014, while India competed at the Asian Games, Inamdar was at

home nursing a fractured leg and following kabaddi on television. His life at the time seemed a world away from an international career. "I was just watching kabaddi on TV. But I believe God's plans are always better. My hard work never stopped."

He kept working. Eventually, the Pro Kabaddi League changed the scale of his life.

In his first season, he earned ₹8 lakh. For someone who had once struggled to put food on the table, the money was almost incomprehensible. "Eight lakh felt like eight crore to me," he said.

He did not forget where he had come from. With his first major earnings, he bought a gold necklace for his mother. Kabaddi had given him something that had once seemed almost impossible: financial security, recognition and a career. He went on to captain Puneri Paltan and establish himself as one of India's leading players. Then came the international medals.

Inamdar won his first Asian Games gold in Hangzhou. Three years later in Nagoya, he has another. And once again, the final was against Iran – the one opponent which has consistently pushed India hardest at the Asian Games. "Iran is generally the most challenging opponent for us," Inamdar said. "It has a strong defence and has very experienced players like Fazel Atrachali, who played in his fifth Asian Games."

For Inamdar, beating such a formidable opponent made the gold more meaningful. "A tough challenge makes winning the gold medal feel even more rewarding."

But for Inamdar, the significance of the medal lies beyond the result. It is the culmination of a journey that began when he was a boy travelling across Maharashtra for a few hundred rupees, when he collected scrap bottles for food and worked whatever jobs he could find before heading to the kabaddi ground.

Today, he tries to pass on that experience to younger players. At his training ground in Thane, he speaks to juniors, particularly those from underprivileged backgrounds, about his own journey. He wants them to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up. "I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have. I want them to know that whatever happens, they shouldn't stop working hard. They shouldn't stop believing," he said.



It still feels like a dream to me. I often think about how someone who didn't even have food at home holds two international medals



Iran is generally the most challenging opponent. It has a strong defence and has experienced players like Fazel Atrachali

THE GIST

The medals are the latest chapter in a journey that began at Takli Bhan in Maharashtra's Ahilyanagar district, where Inamdar grew up as one of five children

He clinched both his gold medals after defeating Iran in finals

The raider wants the next generation to understand that difficult circumstances do not have to determine where they end up

COP31 hosts Australia and Türkiye face the fossil-fuel question

There is likely to be pressure on the COP31 presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26 and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31

Rishika Pardikar
TRABZON, TÜRKİYE

The next United Nations climate change conference, COP31, will be held in Antalya in Türkiye in November this year. Türkiye will be hosting the event, with its Minister of Environment Murat Kurum serving as COP31 President. Australia will oversee the negotiations process, with its Minister for Climate Change and Energy Chris Bowen as the Vice-President of COP31.

This is a novel arrangement – a result of both Australia and Türkiye not being willing to concede their demand to host, and where both countries share crucial responsibilities. In previous editions, the COP’s physical host has differed from the President only for logistical reasons.

A pre-COP event will be held in Fiji on October 5-8, where Pacific Island countries and Australia will discuss preparations for the main event, including what to negotiate. These pre-COPs are a routine affair before the annual summits.

Domestic fossil reliance

Both Türkiye and Australia are heavy users of fossil fuels. Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter, after Russia and the U.S. Domestically, Australia as well as Türkiye rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their energy needs. Three weeks ago, Australia also came under fire from climate groups for approving the expansion of a coal mine.

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn “to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035”.

‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda: Türkiye hosted a ‘Blue Dialogue’ on September 10-11 whose focus was on protecting marine resources.

However, none of the themes listed as a priority for the event make direct reference to transitioning away from fossil fuels.

That said, various industries in Australia, including iron-ore mining, are trying to decarbonise by investing in hybrid or electric heavy machinery. Local governments are also pushing for electric vehicles (EVs), which recently overtook petrol car sales for the first time in Australia.

Türkiye, on the other hand, is working to augment recycling and so eventually reduce methane emissions. In fact, the country has listed ‘zero waste and a circular economy’ on the COP31 priority list. The fortunes of a local EV brand,



An oil rig is visible in the distance near Cape Town harbour. ALPHA PERSPECTIVE/UNSPASH

Togg, has ballooned so much that the government hopes it will herald a new era in the automobiles market.

Loss and damage financing

At the COP30 in Belém, Brazil, last year, the European Union pushed for a “fossil fuel roadmap” to help countries worldwide transition away from fossil fuels. While many countries supported the call, observers have said it took the focus away from developing countries’ calls to triple adaptation finance and developed countries’ resistance to that.

That said, most countries involved in the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) did not oppose the call for the “fossil fuel road map” at COP30.

India did not oppose either, on the condition that it incorporate the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and that countries are not expected to follow uniform energy transition pathways. Beyond the UNFCCC framework as well, and partly because of the slow pace of negotiations at the COP summits, there have been calls for concrete action to transition away from fossil fuels. In April this year, the first conference on “Transitioning Away from Fossil Fuels” was held in Santa Marta in Colombia, co-hosted by Colombia and the Netherlands.

The second conference is scheduled

for 2027, to be co-hosted by Tuvalu and Ireland.

Given such momentum, there is likely to be pressure on the COP31 Presidencies to include fossil fuel language as part of the agenda. The catastrophic floods in Nepal on August 26, boosted no doubt by climate change, and the damage they wrought are also set to add momentum to both mitigation action, including the language surrounding fossil fuels at COP31, and to loss and damage financing. But as with their not mentioning the transition away from fossil fuels, the joint Australia-Türkiye presidents have also included no loss and damage financing, or even the broader climate finance question, among the priority topics.

“We know there are strong views on all sides of this topic,” the Türkiye Presidency said in response to questions from the author about whether this will change. “We will create space for Parties to discuss the transition and listen carefully to the positions they bring forward to see what we can agree by consensus. But listening to Parties’ views on negotiations does not mean we are standing still. We are taking the next logical steps in the energy transition by making electrification the flagship thematic priority of the COP31 Presidency’s Action Agenda, because electrifying buildings, transport and industry is key to reducing emissions and

should be accompanied by complementary efforts to expand renewable energy.

Likewise, the reply said on mitigation financing: “we have been clear that we need to close the climate finance chasm, and we are holding donors to the financial commitments made at past COPs, while also introducing innovative new mechanisms, such as the ‘Climate Implementation Bridge’, to address the gap between ambitious climate plans and the finance needed to make them a reality.”

The Australian Presidency did not respond.

Countries participating at COPs can propose new agenda items for consideration during negotiations. For example, the European Union introduced the “road map” in the formal negotiations agenda at the last minute at COP30. That said, it remains to be seen whether countries will do so at COP31, and if so what the items will be – and ultimately how the event’s two fossil fuel-heavy stewards will navigate negotiations.

The author was in Türkiye September 8-13 at the invitation of the government for a COP31-themed media tour. She also visited Australia in October 2025 on a similar official tour.

(Rishika Pardikar is a freelance journalist. rishika.s.pardikar@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Australia and Türkiye are heavy users of fossil fuels; both countries rely on coal, gas, and oil to generate respectively around 90% and 80% of their domestic energy needs; Australia is the world’s third-largest fossil fuels exporter

The primary goal at COP31 is a target to electrify industry and vehicles and in turn ‘to raise the share of final energy demand met by electricity from just over 20% today to 35% by 2035’; ‘Oceans and Seas’ are also a priority agenda

At COP30, the EU advocated a global ‘fossil fuel roadmap’ to guide the transition away from fossil fuels; critics said it diverted attention from developing nations’ demand for tripling adaptation finance

BIG SHOT



Coastal fury: Waves caused by Hurricane Polo seen battering a small island with houses off the coast of San Blas in Mexico on September 26; It moved away from Mexico's Pacific coast on Saturday as a Category 4 storm and is expected to return to make landfall in Baja California Sur on Monday, forecasters said. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

UN Sea Level Declaration

Vasudevan Mukunth

On September 24, the United Nations General Assembly approved the Declaration on Sea Level Rise by consensus.

Perhaps its most important provision concerns international law. The Declaration affirms that low-lying countries especially threatened by rising seas, such as Fiji, Tuvalu, and Vanuatu, will continue to retain their statehood, sovereign rights, and UN membership. It also says maritime zones will continue to be defined in line with the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea, even if rising waters cause coastlines to retreat further inland.

The Declaration arose from a high-level meeting in 2024 and which member countries had since negotiated under a mandate calling for an action-oriented agreement. Spanning four pages, the Declaration organises action around (i) science and data, (ii) adaptation and financing, (iii) livelihoods, socio-economic development, data-sharing, and early-warnings, and (iv) the legal consequences of sea-level rise.

It also calls on countries to respond to sea-level rise in a way that addresses livelihoods and cultural heritage and with the involvement of affected communities.

The world’s low-lying island states — which have organised themselves as the Alliance of Small Island States in international fora, including the COP



The current global mean sea-level rise is 4-5 mm/year. LOOK UP LOOK DOWN PHOTOGRAPHY/UNSPASH

climate talks — need these assurances because the seas surrounding them threaten to swallow most or all of their habitable territory in the coming decades. If they do, the Declaration will ensure their citizens continue to retain their nationality and economic rights.

The pact also commits UN member countries to continue to engage on issues related to sea-level rise, including a high-level meeting before the 84th session of the General Assembly ends.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people rescued during floods in Chhattisgarh

5,000 Nearly 5,000 people were rescued in the last two days after heavy rains swelled rivers in Chhattisgarh, officials said on Sunday. The administration has set up 43 relief camps in urban and rural areas of the Bastar district. The Indravati river level rose to 12.56 metres by 8 p.m. on Saturday, 4.26 metres above the danger mark. PTI

People who died in separate mass shootings in S. Africa

27 The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg. The second happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town. No arrests had been made in the two shootings, which came just five days after another mass shooting near the city of Durban killed at least 11 people. Shootings are the most common form of homicide in South Africa. PTI

Palestinians killed by Israel in Gaza since October 2023

74,016 While a ceasefire that took effect on October 10 last year has halted the heaviest fighting, Israeli strikes have continued in what the military described as responses to threats or attacks. Since the ceasefire, 1,145 Palestinians have been killed, said the Ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led government. PTI

Missing trainee teachers honoured by protesters in Mexico

43 Thousands of protesters wore red and carried symbolic coffins at a demonstration in Mexico City on Saturday, demanding answers about the 43 trainee teachers who went missing 12 years ago. Prosecutors initially said officers delivered the teacher trainees to drug cartel hitmen, who killed them. Independent human rights experts have rejected the conclusion. AFP

People rescued from child trafficking racket in Arunachal Pradesh

51 According to Namsai Superintendent of Police Sange Thinley, sustained investigation and coordinated operations led to a significant jump in rescued children from 19 during the initial phase to 51, including four adults. During the initial crackdown, the police rescued 19 children, most of them below eight years of age. PTI

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Should voting be a fundamental right?

A recent *Indian Express* report revealed an unprecedented rift within the EC over alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, prompting a re-examination of the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one

LETTER & SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh

On September 23, an *Indian Express* investigation revealed an unprecedented rift within the three-member Election Commission of India (EC), with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recording 14 objections over 10 months against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, regarding alleged unilateral changes to rules, voter additions/deletions, and centralised data access, without the Commission’s full approval.

The report also found that 97 eligible voters from Goa were excluded from the electoral roll after the centralised ECINet software prevented ground-level Electoral Registration Officers (ERO) from reversing decisions. More concerning, the consequences extend beyond the loss of voting rights. Reportedly, several State schemes use electoral rolls to establish eligibility, including the Goa Mediclaim Scheme. The scheme covers super-speciality treatments unavailable in government hospitals, such as dialysis, angioplasty, open-heart surgery, transplants, chemotherapy and cochlear implants, and is available only to State voters. This issue has once again cast a spotlight on the ‘right to vote’, the foundational processes of India’s electoral machinery, and the genesis of India’s ‘universal adult suffrage’ (UAS).

What shaped adult suffrage in India? India’s constitutional promise of the ‘right to vote’ differs significantly from that of many Western democracies. Reflecting the flawed belief, espoused by thinkers like J.S. Mill, that voting should be reserved for the “enlightened”, countries like the U.K. initially restricted the franchise to male property owners. Universal male suffrage emerged only in 1918, and women were granted the ‘right to vote’ a decade later in 1928. In the U.S., although the 15th and 19th Amendments extended voting rights to African Americans (1870) and women (1920), systemic barriers such as poll taxes and literacy tests continued to disenfranchise many for decades thereafter.

In sharp contrast, India’s choice of immediate, universal inclusion ensured ‘democratic equality’ from the outset, bypassing the prolonged and often violent struggles seen elsewhere. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’, regardless of gender, caste, religion, education, or property. This commitment to a robust, inclusive democracy found further constitutional reinforcement in a series of Supreme Court judgments, notably starting with *Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala* (1973), which established democracy as part of the ‘basic structure’ doctrine. For this ideal to function meaningfully, people should be able to freely decide the fate of their government.

This inclusive vision was operationalised through two key laws: the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which governs the preparation and revision of electoral rolls; and the 1951 Act, which regulates election conduct, candidature, and electoral offences. The EC has repeatedly introduced administrative innovations to realise this ‘constitutional promise’.

Notably, the then Chief Election Commissioner Sukumar Sen, faced with the task of enrolling 173 million largely illiterate voters, turned a logistical hurdle into a democratic breakthrough by



Enabling democracy: Courts have regarded the right to vote as an inseparable part of democracy, as it enables citizens to shape governance. R. ASHOK

introducing election symbols, making UAS practically accessible.

In India, the EC has the responsibility to reach the last citizen, wherever they may be, to actualise their ‘right to elect’.

What is the legal status of right to vote?

The legal status of the ‘right to vote’ in India has long been debated, and whether it is classified as a statutory, constitutional, or fundamental right determines how easily it can be changed, how it is enforced, and the level of legal protection it receives. Although Dr. B.R. Ambedkar and K.T. Shah proposed including it in the Constitution’s fundamental rights part, the Constituent Assembly’s Advisory Committee ultimately rejected the idea. Importantly, a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in *Kuldip Nayar v. Union of India* (2006) held that the ‘right to elect’ is a statutory right under Section 62 of the RPA, 1951, and not a fundamental or constitutional right.

Though a two-judge Bench in *Rajbala v. State of Haryana* described the ‘right to vote’ as a constitutional right in 2015, the larger bench ruling in *Kuldip Nayar* prevails. Again, in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India* (2023), the top court declined to pronounce on the issue, noting that it had already been settled by the five-judge Bench in the *Kuldip Nayar* judgment. However, in his dissent, Justice Ajay Rastogi asserted that the ‘right to vote’ is an expression of Article 19(1)(a) and reflects the essence of Article 21. Yet, as this view remains a minority opinion, the ‘right to elect’ continues to be recognised as a statutory right.

Nevertheless, even though it is not a fundamental right, courts have regarded the ‘right to vote’ as an inseparable part of democracy, anchoring their reasoning in the idea that it enables citizens to shape governance, making it a “democratic imperative” vital to the Indian republic’s survival.

Why do we need accurate poll rolls?

Free and fair elections rest on accurate electoral rolls under the RPA, 1950. Inaccuracies – such as mass omissions, ineligible inclusions, duplicates, or incorrect entries – undermine the “one person, one vote” principle by enabling impersonation, disenfranchisement, or

dilution of votes, ultimately distorting the people’s mandate. Therefore, the EC is empowered under Section 21 of the 1950 Act to prepare and revise these rolls to ensure integrity. The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 lays down how the EC must transact its business. Section 17 requires the Commission’s business to be conducted in accordance with the Act, while Section 18 provides that its procedure and allocation of business may be regulated by unanimous decision. It further requires business to be transacted as far as possible unanimously, but where the CEC and other Commissioners differ, the matter is decided by majority.

Deriving its authority from Article 324, the EC serves as the constitutional guardian of elections, with powers of superintendence, direction, and control. A key duty is preparing accurate electoral rolls, guided by Section 19 of the RPA, 1950, which mandates that any citizen aged 18 or above, “ordinarily resident” in a constituency and not disqualified, is entitled to be registered. “Ordinary resident” implies a genuine, continuous presence, not a temporary stay.

While discrepancies may arise, courts have consistently held that only substantial and systemic errors that demonstrably “materially affected” the election outcome can compromise the sanctity of the electoral roll. Minor mistakes or isolated disenfranchisement are insufficient.

Yet the recent Goa episode complicates this comfortable “substantial versus isolated” binary that courts have relied on. The *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters were dropped from the rolls, not through electoral fraud but because the ECINet software architecture itself denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. What makes the episode damning is not merely the exclusion, but the apparent unresponsiveness that followed. The EROs reportedly flagged the anomalies to the Commission by email, yet the corrections were not restored. This is not the isolated clerical error that courts have historically forgiven; it is a systemic failure baked into the software’s design, compounded by administrative inertia.

While the right to inclusion or

objection in electoral rolls is conferred on individuals, not political parties, the court in *Lakshmi Charan Sen v. A.K.M. Hassan Uzzaman* (1985) observed that in a largely illiterate and politically unaware electorate, parties should take steps to ensure eligible voters are included, and ineligible ones are removed. Given India’s party-based Parliamentary system, such vigilance will help in preserving ‘electoral integrity’.

What lies ahead?

The revelations against the EC lend fresh urgency to the argument that the ‘right to vote’ ought to be elevated from a statutory guarantee to a fundamental one. If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the franchise can itself be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will, is precarious.

Many scholars argue that the ‘right to vote’ cannot be regarded as merely a statutory right, as it flows from Article 326, and any legislation regulating it must conform to the parameters prescribed by Articles 325 and 326. It is therefore necessary to ensure that the legislature does not impose irrational or unreasonable restrictions on the ‘right to vote’, particularly since “free and fair elections” and “democracy” are basic features of the Constitution.

Justice Rastogi’s dissent in *Anoop Baranwal*, over the legal status of the ‘right to vote’, offers doctrinal ground for a larger Bench to revisit the question that the majority in *Kuldip Nayar* considered settled.

Elevating the ‘right to vote’ to fundamental status would not diminish the EC’s authority to purify rolls; it would instead subject that authority to the heightened standard of judicial review reserved for fundamental rights, ensuring that the drive to centralise electoral administration is always weighed against, rather than allowed to override, the citizen’s claim to be counted. In a democracy where software now mediates the relationship between the voter and the ballot, the constitutional status of the ‘right to vote’ can no longer remain a matter of legislative grace. (*Kartikey Singh is a lawyer based in New Delhi.*)

THE GIST

India’s choice of immediate, universal adult suffrage ensured democratic equality from the outset. Article 326 of the Constitution granted every adult citizen the ‘right to vote’

An *Indian Express* report revealed that 97 eligible voters from Goa were dropped from the rolls because the ECINet software denied EROs the authority to reverse erroneous deletions. This is not an isolated clerical error, but a systemic failure, compounded by administrative inertia

If the body constitutionally tasked with safeguarding the voting rights can be riven by disputes over unilateral action, leaving the citizen’s only recourse to the EC’s internal correction mechanisms, or to a statutory right that the Parliament could dilute at will is precarious

